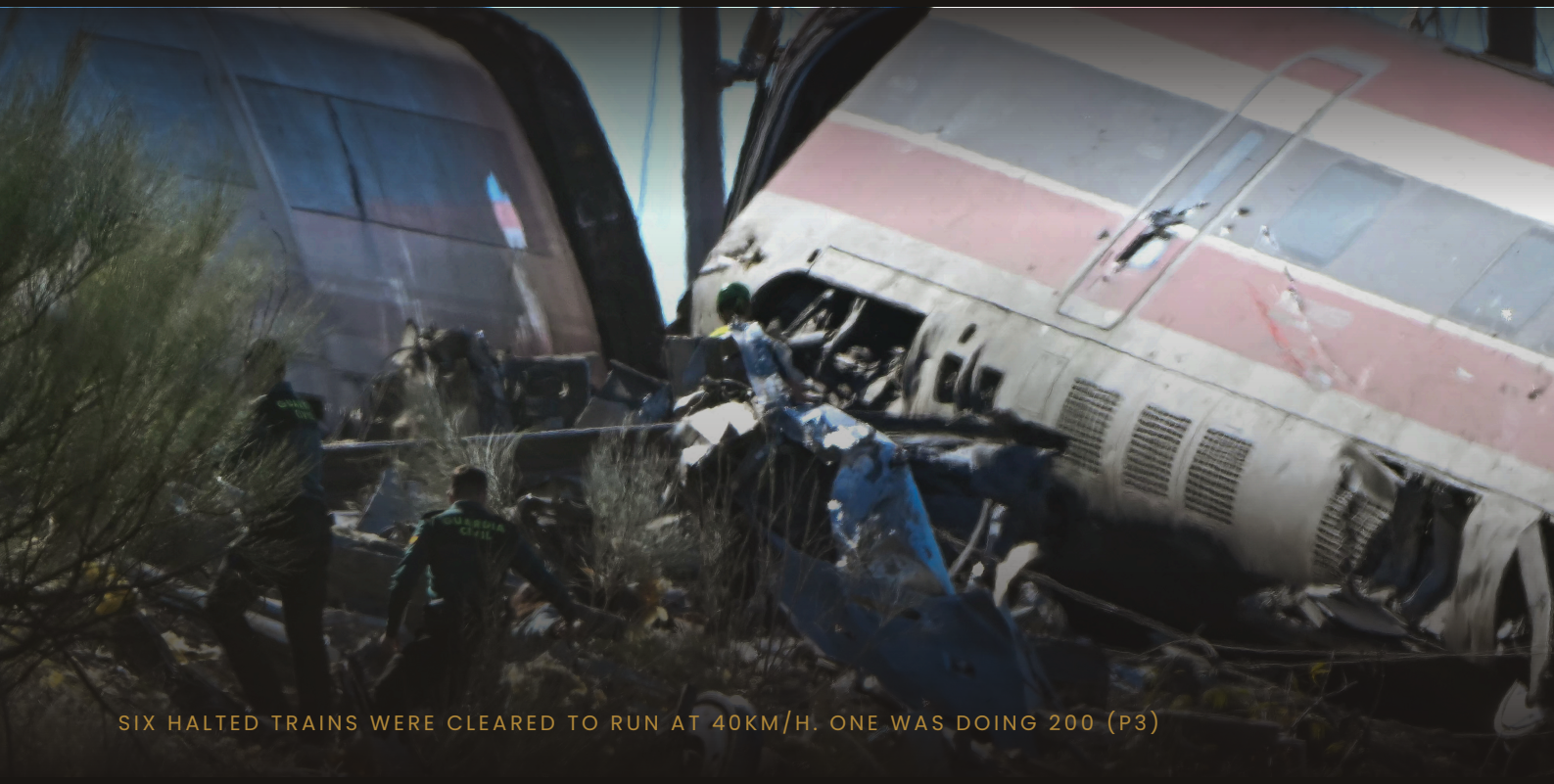
NO. 147 · SINGAPORE

THE CURRENT BRIEFING OF

# MERIDIAN

*Twelve desks. One world.*

THURSDAY 29 OCTOBER 2026



SIX HALTED TRAINS WERE CLEARED TO RUN AT 40KM/H. ONE WAS DOING 200 (P3)

TECHNOLOGY

**Anthropic's prospectus names $637bn of compute deals and leaves the total blank**

THE RABBIT HOLE

**Marquetry: an £80 kit, a $2,500 donkey, and a society that will not count itself**

THE LONG READ

**Pakistan will build an Urdu model; Urdu is 0.03 per cent of the web**



Source: Javier Soriano / AFP, via Al Jazeera. Rescue workers at the collision site near Urda, Toledo, 28 October 2026.

THIS ISSUE · NO. 147

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**THE MEASUREMENT NOBODY TOOK.** A spine ran through this issue without being looked for. A control centre cleared six trains and the one number that mattered did not travel with the clearance (p3). A prospectus states its revenue to the dollar and its largest obligation as a blank (p7). A central bank voted the day before the inflation print it said it was waiting for (p14). A flagship headphone has been on sale five days and nobody has measured it (p10). And on p18, the inverse: a measurement that was finally taken, carefully, and turned out to add nothing.

FROM THE DESK

*"The limits of my language mean the limits of my world."*

**Ludwig Wittgenstein, *Tractatus Logico-Philosophicus*, proposition 5.6, 1921**[1]

Usually read as a claim about thought. It earns its place here as a claim about records: a machine can only be taught what somebody troubled to write down (p21).

## THE STRIP · AT WEDNESDAY'S CLOSE

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| **US 10-year**[2] | 5.05% | ▲ 6bp |
| **US 2-year**[2] | 4.67% | ▼ 3bp |
| **VWRA** | $191.64 | ▲ 0.18% |
| **AGGU** | $5.79 | — |
| **Brent** | $114.10 | ▲ 0.19% |
| **Gold** | $4,081.20 | ▲ 0.16% |
| **Bitcoin** | $81,350 | ▲ 0.67% |
| **USD/SGD** | 1.2805 | — |
| **STI** | 5,397.91 | ▲ 0.02% |

**The ten-year rose 6bp on a hold and the two-year fell 3.** That is duration being repriced, not money (p14). Not advice.[2]

## SIX NUMBERS FROM THIS ISSUE

**Forty kilometres an hour.** The proceed-on-sight cap a control centre's own clearance put on six resuming Spanish trains. The one that hit was doing about two hundred (p3).

**Five times.** Occurrences of "more than $ ", with no figure after it, in a prospectus filed three days ago (p7).

**Nought of seven.** Outcomes in a study of 23,938 Icelandic teenagers that cleared its own significance threshold after their schools banned phones (p12).

**Four hundred and two.** Active editors maintaining Urdu Wikipedia, one of the curated sources a national language model is to be trained on (p21).

**Nought point seven four seven against nought point seven four four.** A nurse with a stopwatch, and nine days of wrist sensor, predicting death equally well (p18).

**Twelve weeks.** The lead time on a live-edge sit-stand desk from a Kansas City workshop that declines to name the frame it ships on (p6).

**SOURCES** 1 Ludwig Wittgenstein, *Tractatus Logico-Philosophicus* (1921), proposition 5.6, as rendered in the standard English editions. 2 Levels at Wednesday's close, each read at its own source and sourced individually on p14, where the Treasury's own daily curve supplies both yields.

THE WORLD · THE TOLEDO COLLISION

# Renfe's AVE hit a stopped Iryo train near Toledo; at least 68 died

*Spain's transport minister says Adif's control centre cleared six halted trains to resume after an eight-minute signalling failure, capping them at 40km/h — and the AVE was doing about 200.*

At about **08:53** on Wednesday morning, Renfe's high-speed service **2080** from Madrid to Seville ran into the stationary rear of Iryo's **6076** at kilometre **118** of the Madrid–Seville line, between Los Yébenes and Urda in Toledo province. At least **68** of the **544** aboard were killed, and Spain entered three days of mourning at midnight. It is the country's second high-speed disaster of 2026: Adamuz killed **46** in January.[1]

The mechanism is already on the record, and it is not about brakes. Transport minister **Óscar Puente**'s own account is that the **LZB** train-supervision system failed at **08:32**, halting six trains across a 90km stretch. Adif's Atocha control centre authorised all six to resume about eight minutes later under *marcha a la vista* — proceed-on-sight rules that cap a train at **40km/h**. The Iryo driver opened contact to restart at 08:38. The AVE that hit him was doing about **200km/h**.[2]

Even the clock is contested: Iryo puts the impact at **08:48**, Renfe and the ministry at 08:53. Nobody has reconciled them, and the gap between clearance and impact is the whole question. The toll moved four times in six hours — at least 30, then **64**, then **68** by mid-afternoon — and by evening the region counted **107 admitted, 15 serious**. Xinhua and CGTN were still printing 64 as this page closed.[3]

The Guardia Civil questioned the Atocha operator at 15:35 with **422** officers on site; at 21:15 the court at Orgaz sealed the scene and seized the black boxes. Prime minister **Pedro Sánchez** called two such crashes inside a year "no asumible" and promised that "if there has been negligence, it will be known". Puente called the control centre's decision "inexplicable" and "erróneo", said LZB is already being replaced, and refused to resign.[2]

> ***"A rear-end collision on the high-speed network is truly implausible."***

### THE CHATTER · THE ENGINEERS ASKED FIRST

On Hacker News the thread ran to **164 points and 184 comments** inside a day. **ethfan** put the technical question before any minister did: "When LZB drops out, does the fallback to ASFA plus verbal authorization actually enforce block separation, or is it basically just driver discipline at 300 km/h?" And **nemoniac** made the pedantic correction that is the story: "A high-speed train collided with a stationary train."[4]

### THE SCEPTIC · THE UNIONS REJECT THE HUMAN-ERROR FRAME

The sharpest line came from the company whose train was hit. **Carlos Bertomeu**, chairman of Iryo: it "should never have happened, and it has happened again". **Miguel Ángel Gimeno** of the rail traffic union called it "lamentable" that human error was named before the experts had finished. The falsification test is specific: the seized black boxes and the Atocha logs will show whether the AVE's authorisation carried the 40km/h cap. If it did not, this stops being a driver story.[5]

**40 km/h**

THE PROCEED-ON-SIGHT CAP THE CONTROL CENTRE'S OWN AUTHORISATION IMPOSED ON SIX RESUMING TRAINS — ONE FIFTH OF THE SPEED THE AVE WAS CARRYING[2]

## ALSO IN THE WORLD

**Damascus has closed its main crossing with Jordan.** The new fact on the strikes this magazine reported yesterday: Syrian civil defence puts the toll from Jordan's Monday-night raids in Daraa and Sweida at **seven**, five of them one family in a tent. Damascus still says the operation came "without prior coordination or notification".[3]

**Hebron's lockdown entered a sixth day.** UNRWA says it has displaced nearly **5,000** Palestinians; West Bank director **Roland Friedrich** warned of "alarming echoes" of early 2025, when more than **34,000** were displaced from Jenin, Tulkarem and Nur Shams and have still not returned.[3]

**SOURCES** 1 Associated Press copy via The Times of Israel, 28 October, and Al Jazeera's running report; the Adamuz comparison from Spanish business-press coverage of Adif's suspension. **Reuters, AP's own site, the BBC and the Guardian all refused this desk**, so the wire copy is read through outlets that carry it. 2 The transport ministry's account as logged through Wednesday by a Spanish daily's live file, and the public broadcaster's log of the minister's remarks; **Adif's own press room returned 404**. 3 Casualty revisions from the public broadcaster's timestamped log; the Syria and Hebron items from The Times of Israel and Al Jazeera respectively. 4 Hacker News item 50272596, by signed username; **Reddit returned 403 for the fourteenth issue running.** 5 Iryo's chairman and the traffic union as logged by the public broadcaster, 28 October.

THE WORLD · ISRAEL'S COUNT

# Israel's count gives Netanyahu 53 seats, Eisenkot 48, the Arab parties 19

*At 89.8 per cent counted on Wednesday evening neither bloc could reach 61: Benjamin Netanyahu is down from 68 seats and the Arab parties are up from 10, their best result ever.*

Israel's Central Elections Committee had counted **89.8 per cent** of Tuesday's ballots by 21:00 on Wednesday, and the shape had not moved: Benjamin Netanyahu's bloc **53**, Gadi Eisenkot's **48**, the Arab parties **19**, in a Knesset of 120 where **61** governs. **Likud 26**, Yashar 21, B'Yachad 12, the **Joint List 12**, the Democrats 8, then Otzma Yehudit, Shas, United Torah Judaism, **Ra'am** and Yisrael Beytenu on 7 each, Religious Zionism 6.[1]

What is still out is smaller than it looked: the committee now estimates **430,000 to 480,000** double-envelope ballots — soldiers, prisoners, diplomats — revised down from 600,000. Counting began at **01:00 on Thursday**; certification is **4 November**. President Isaac Herzog then nominates whoever has the best chance, who gets **28 days plus a 14-day extension**. Turnout was **77.7 per cent**, the highest since 1999.[2]

Likud's answer was to allege theft: its Wednesday statement said the election "was stolen by Arab parties that support terror", claiming bribery and illegal mobilisation software. The committee said it had opened its standard integrity operation, having already told Channel 12 the claims were unfounded.[1]

## *"Don't you dare use Israel's security for your political needs."*

**DOHA** — **AL JAZEERA**

A "referendum on Netanyahu's leadership", set against "Israel's genocidal war on Gaza". The Arab parties are the tie-breaker: both blocs are "locked out of the majority without the Arab vote".[3]

**MOSCOW** — **RT**

Murad Sadygzade of HSE University: "His political position has undoubtedly weakened, but this does not yet amount to his removal from power." High turnout "exposed deep fatigue with crisis and war". **TASS carried no Israel item at all.**[3]

**BEIJING** — **XINHUA**

Twelve hours behind and deliberately flat: still headlined on exit polls, no seat numbers, no quotes. **Global Times ran no Israel opinion; CGTN's copy is AFP's.** Sitting it out is itself the position.[3]

"The Israeli regime" throughout, and 7 October 2023 the "al-Aqsa Storm resistance operation". Its numbers are exit-poll vintage and now wrong.[3]

### THE CHATTER · THE MONEY IS A COIN FLIP

Reddit refused this desk again and Hacker News never opened a thread, so the honest crowd signal is the betting book. On Polymarket's next-prime-minister market — **US$78.0m** traded, US$10.2m of it in 24 hours — **Netanyahu sat at 50.0 per cent** against Eisenkot's 25.9. A separate market had Ra'am's seven seats at **78.1 per cent**: the Arab surge was priced before it was counted.[4]

### THE SCEPTIC · THE LAST BALLOTS WILL NOT SAVE ANYONE

**Assaf Shapira**, who runs the Israel Democracy Institute's political reform programme, on the half-million uncounted votes: "I don't predict that it will make a lot of difference." He expects one or two seats to move between parties, no more. **Sylvaine Bulle** of EHESS in Paris supplies the warning everyone is ignoring — of the opposition and the Arab lists, "you cannot simply add their seats." Eisenkot has set four conditions for working with them; **Amjad Shbita** of the Joint List has already refused the format: "We will negotiate as equals."[5]

### ALSO AROUND THE DESKS

**Flávio Bolsonaro walked into Argentina and flew to Miami.** Lula won Brazil's 25 October runoff **51.79** to 48.21. Justice Alexandre de Moraes then ordered Bolsonaro to surrender both passports over a money-laundering investigation; he missed the deadline, crossed on foot into Argentina late on Tuesday and landed at Opa-Locka on a US-issued visa. **Lula: "his decision to leave Brazil is shameful."**[6]

**SOURCES** 1 Central Elections Committee figures as published by The Times of Israel and the Jerusalem Post, 28 October, identically at both; the committee's own portal **refused DNS and serves a JavaScript shell**, so no page of its own was read. Note the framing split: the Post counts the opposition at 48, Haaretz at 67, on the same arithmetic. 2 The revised double-envelope estimate and the mandate clock, via The Times of Israel and Anadolu; turnout attributed to the committee by Al Jazeera and CNN. 3 Each outlet's own page, read 28 October. 4 Polymarket order books, read 28 October. 5 Shapira via The Times of Israel; Bulle and Shbita via France 24/AFP. 6 Al Jazeera, reporting from Opa-Locka, with the vote shares from Brazil's electoral court — **whose own page returned 403, so they are confirmed through Xinhua instead**, which was still calling the departure officially unconfirmed.

SINGAPORE · THE HAZE NOTICES

# Shanmugam summons ten firms as Singapore arms the NEA with haze assessors

*Shanmugam told leaders of ten Singapore-registered companies on Wednesday that Section 10 notices are "not routine requests"; the amendments reach Parliament on 3 November, and the firms will pay for the assessors.*

Senior Minister **K. Shanmugam**, Deputy Prime Minister **Gan Kim Yong** and Sustainability Minister **Grace Fu** met senior leaders of the **ten** Singapore-registered companies served notices under the Transboundary Haze Pollution Act on **Wednesday**, behind closed doors, with the Attorney-General's Chambers and the National Environment Agency present. Eight representatives covered ten entities. Shanmugam: "These are formal statutory notices. They are not routine requests for information."[1]

The news is not the meeting but what follows it. When Parliament sits on **3 November** the Government will move amendments giving NEA power to **direct any entity it suspects of connection to the fires to appoint assessors** — and to make failure to appoint, or to cooperate fully, an offence. Assessors get access to documents, sites, operations and supply chains. **NEA assigns the teams and writes the terms of reference; the companies pay the bill.** Each team pairs an investigations firm with a law firm advising the investigator, not the company.[2]

The reason for the new machinery is the old machinery's record. The Act carries a penalty of up to **S$100,000 a day**, capped at S$2 million, and in the twelve years since 2014 there have been **no prosecutions at all**. Four Indonesian firms were served in 2015; no suits, no fines, and **three of those four are implicated again this year**. Of the ten served on 23 October, three acknowledged without committing to cooperate.[3]

Alongside it runs a quieter dispute about gas. Indonesia began cutting piped exports on **24 October** from the Natuna and Sumatra fields, days after coordinating minister **Bahlil Lahadalia** said he "will not hesitate to consider stopping exports to countries that do not respect Indonesia". The two governments do not agree on the size: Jakarta's SKK Migas says **31 BBTUD**, Singapore's Energy Market Authority counts **17** — under 2 per cent of demand. Energy minister **Tan See Leng**: "keep calm and carry on".[4]

### THE CHATTER · CREDIT TO THE MAN, NOT THE OUTCOME

HardwareZone's thread ran to **69 replies and 3,000 views** in a day, and the split is consistent. **GreatPumpkin**: "For things within his control, Shan really went ahead and squeezed." Against him, **trento**: "I'll only believe when i see pap close down these companies. Meantime, it's just all talk." **qcy888** gave the one-word verdict: "wayang".[5]

### THE SCEPTIC · A LAW THAT CANNOT CROSS THE BORDER

**Helena Varkkey** of the University of Malaya, who studies the politics of the haze, calls the record "influence without enforcement, rather than straightforward failure" — the limits of acting extraterritorially. **Ang Peng Hwa** of NTU, who co-founded the Haze Elimination Action Team: "There was no criminal suit and we don't have the resources to go to the ground to prove those cases." And the Malaysian Bar's **Kiu Jia Yaw**: "This is a state of organized irresponsibility."[6]

**S$100,000**

THE MAXIMUM DAILY FINE UNDER THE HAZE ACT — AGAINST ZERO PROSECUTIONS IN THE TWELVE YEARS SINCE IT PASSED[3]

**MAS held the band on 14 October**, with core inflation at **2.1 per cent** for July and August against 1.5 in the second quarter. September CPI came in at **2.2**, core **2.0**.[7]

**SOURCES** 1 Mothership and AsiaOne reports of the 28 October meeting, carrying the ministers' remarks; **the two outlets differ on whether ten or eleven entities were represented, and neither states the venue.** 2 The proposed amendments and the specialist-panel mechanism, from Yahoo Singapore's report of the same briefing and Mothership's. 3 Penalty, the zero-prosecution record and the 2015 precedent from Mongabay, 27 October, and The Star's report of Grace Fu's 27 October remarks; the compliance split from timestamped SGX filings as collated by The Star. 4 EMA's statement via AsiaOne, SKK Migas via Mothership, and Tan See Leng's remarks of 25 October via The Star. 5 HardwareZone, by handle — **Reddit refused this desk again, and HardwareZone's own search endpoint returned 403.** 6 All four quoted in Mongabay's 27 October investigation. 7 NEA's own haze advisory of 28 October; the MAS monetary policy statement of 14 October; **September CPI read at a data aggregator, SingStat having refused — the one load-bearing Singapore figure here not read at its primary.**

THE ATELIER · DESKS & WORKTOPS

# Jiecang builds the base under a $599 Uplift and a $2,349 Jarvis alike

*The Chinese actuator house also bought Austria's Logicdata for €79.18m in 2021 — and Linak's own data sheet rates a desk column for two minutes of movement in every twenty.*

Start with who actually makes the thing. **Jiecang Linear Motion Technology** of Zhejiang — 5,000 staff and **RMB 4.03bn** of turnover in 2025 — is named by three independent reviewers as the OEM behind Uplift, Evodesk and the Jarvis. In July 2021 it bought **Logicdata**, the Austrian premium-controls house, for **€79.18m**; Logicdata's own site now says it operates "as part of the JIECANG Group". Logicdata is **reported** — by the deal's Chinese coverage, not by the brands — to supply Herman Miller and Steelcase.[1]

The material is simpler than the marketing. BTOD spanned desktops 32 inches apart and hung 150 then 250lb in the middle, and found **"thickness mattered far more than material type"** — at equal thickness bamboo and laminate differed negligibly. Stiffness scales with the **cube** of thickness, so a 40mm top resists bending about four times better than a 25mm one. The published tolerance is **0.02in of sag per foot**, and that is initial sag only, because particleboard keeps creeping.[2]

The spec nobody prints is the duty cycle. Linak's DL11 sheet gives **800N per column**, 38mm/s, three stages, 7.5kg, a dynamic bending moment of **150Nm** — and a duty cycle of **"10% ≈ max. 2 minutes continuous use at full load followed by 18 minutes pause"**. It is a positioning device, not a lift. Note what the badge buys: IKEA's IDÅSEN genuinely runs Linak columns, derated to **70kg** — barely half what two standard DL11s push.[3]

## WHAT THE LADDER COSTS

**Entry of quality, S$269:** IKEA TROTTEN, manual crank, 50kg, ten years — no motor to fail. **The sweet spot, S$919 or US$599:** the IDÅSEN buys Linak columns and a hackable Bluetooth paddle at a 70kg ceiling; the UPLIFT V3 a Jiecang base claiming 355lb with fifteen years of paper. **The grail:** KC Custom Hardwoods, **US$2,825–4,875 at twelve weeks** — and it does not name the frame it ships on. **Above about US$900 every dollar buys grain, not engineering.**[4]

### THE CHATTER · BUY THE CROSSBAR, NOT THE SECOND MOTOR

The strongest sentiment here is about geometry, not brands. **hnexamazon**, who owns both: "Uplift (with crossbar) has vastly superior stability at standing heights… The Jarvis has noticeable sway just using a keyboard and mouse." On the four-leg upsell: "Unless you are putting seriously heavy stuff on top I don't think you need 4 legs."[5]

### THE SCEPTIC · THE HEADLINE IS TEN, THE MOTOR IS THREE

Cochrane: sit-stand desks cut workplace sitting by 84 to 116 minutes a day at first, falling to **57 at three to twelve months**, on **"low-quality evidence"** — and the outcome measured is sitting, not health. **Matt Buman** of Arizona State: **"There's just not enough evidence to claim that sitting is even comparable to smoking."** Then the paperwork: **Omnidesk advertises ten years and its own warranty page gives three on the motor**, with no term for frame or top.[6]

### NEXT ON THE BENCH

**Over-ear headphones** — the transducer houses behind the badges, and which obsessives already know.

**Leather gloves** — the few ateliers that cut and sew for a great many labels, and fit as a measurement.

**Rules & squares** — the tools that decide whether the cut is true, from makers nobody advertises.

**Singapore.** Furniture attracts no duty here, only GST on the CIF value — so the freight is taxed too. Omnidesk prices locally; MyDesk builds bespoke out of Sim Lim Square; **Desky's Singapore domain redirects offshore**. Read Linak's envelope before buying the badge: **20 to 80 per cent relative humidity, non-condensing**. **No non-commercial Singapore source on indoor humidity for a wide solid top exists.** Seal both faces, and fix it so it can move.[7]

**SOURCES** 1 Jiecang's own corporate page for scale; BTOD and WorkWhileWalking, three separate reviews, for the OEM relationship — **review press, not a manufacturer disclosure**; Turquoise's deal announcement and Logicdata's own company page for the acquisition; the Herman Miller and Steelcase supply line is **reported by Yicai Global and traced to Jiecang's own statement, not confirmed by either brand**. 2 BTOD's loaded-deflection test; the Sagulator's published tolerance; white oak's modulus and shrinkage from the wood database. 3 Linak's DL11 data sheet, read from Linak's own CDN; the IDÅSEN's 70kg from IKEA Singapore's own page. 4 Prices read at each storefront on 28 October; **Vitra, Herman Miller's and Steelcase's warranty pages, Home Depot and Berkeley Mills all refused or 404'd, so their tiers are absent rather than estimated.** 5 Hacker News item 23676346, by signed username; **Reddit was not attempted, having refused all year.** 6 Cochrane's plain-language summary of 17 December 2018; Buman via Arizona State's own account of his 2018 paper, **the journal itself having returned 403**; Omnidesk's and Uplift's own warranty pages. 7 Singapore Customs' import procedures page; MyDesk's and Omnidesk's own pages; the Desky redirect followed on 28 October.

TECHNOLOGY · THE ANTHROPIC FILING

# Anthropic's S-1 names $637bn of compute deals and leaves the total blank

*Broadcom alone is $161.2bn of five-year equipment leases, Google $114.5bn and SpaceX up to $120.5bn at about $3.1bn a month from December — while the summary line still reads "more than $ ".*

Anthropic, PBC filed its Form **S-1** with the Securities and Exchange Commission on **26 October**, registration **333-299633**, applying to list on Nasdaq as **ANT** through Goldman Sachs and Morgan Stanley. This magazine reported yesterday that the aggregate compute commitment is left blank. It is blank in **five** places, not four, and as of Wednesday **no amendment has been filed**.[1]

What is not blank is the trade. Revenue ran **$41m** in 2023, **$386m** in 2024, **$4,585m** in 2025, and **$16,286m** in the first half of 2026. The quarterly series is the striking one: **$4,731m** in the first quarter of 2026, **$11,555m** in the second. Operating loss narrowed to **$693m**; the **$80,748m** net loss is almost entirely a **$72,388m** non-cash revaluation of convertible notes, against **$131.7bn** of cash on 30 June.[2]

Against that sits the obligation the summary will not add up. Seven named counterparties total **$637.0bn** by this desk's own arithmetic; a further Google tranche estimated at **$125bn to $150bn** and an AMD option above **$20bn** are described but not committed — which is how one document supports published totals of $450bn, $518bn and $537bn, depending on what the reader counts. The **SpaceX.AI** arrangement, the former X.AI, runs at roughly **$3.1bn a month** once capacity lands.[1]

| COUNTERPARTY | COMMITTED |
|---|---|
| **Broadcom (finance leases)** | $161.2bn |
| **Google** | $114.5bn |
| **SpaceX.AI** | $120.5bn |
| **Amazon** | $110.0bn |
| **Microsoft** | $44.9bn |
| **Nscale** | $44.6bn |
| **Lambda** | $41.3bn |

Named fixed commitments in the S-1. **The sum is this magazine's; the filing prints no total.**[1]

### THE CHATTER · IS THE EIGHTY BILLION REAL

The Hacker News thread took **1,700 points and 1,673 comments** and split on exactly that. **npilk**: "That's sort of a paper loss though." **epsteingpt**: "They are costs." **Rury** moved it where it belongs: "The real liabilities are the hundreds of billions in non-cancelable compute costs Anthropic owes Google, Amazon etc."[3]

### THE SCEPTIC · BURRY REACHES FOR 1998

**Michael Burry** compares the structure to the 1998–2002 telecom buildout and 1960s computer leasing, and warns that the interconnectedness "creates an illusion of security during an expansionary phase". He puts commitments at **~$537bn**, over **20×** trailing sales. Three checkable figures hold against the filing — Broadcom's $161.2bn, the **48 per cent** of first-half revenue billed through hyperscaler marketplaces, the **58 per cent** of receivables. One does not: his **$1.70** revenue per compute dollar implies third-quarter data the S-1 does not contain. **Read via a secondary.**[4]

**900%**

NET REVENUE RETENTION AT 30 SEPTEMBER 2026, WITH CUSTOMERS ABOVE $100,000 OF TRAILING REVENUE UP FROM 950 TO 11,900 IN A YEAR[2]

### SETTING THE RECORD STRAIGHT, AND ALSO ON THIS DESK

**A correction.** No. 146 said the S-1 leaves Q3 revenue "blank three times". It does not: the financial statements **stop at 30 June**, and the filed document's own title reads "S-1 (Q2)". There is no third-quarter revenue figure in the document to blank. The nine-month disclosures are percentages and operating metrics only. The compute blanks stand, and there are five of them.[1]

**Google shipped Gemini 4 Carbon and will not let you have it.** Announced **28 October**, two weeks after Argon: first to "a subset of cyber defenders", then vetted partners. It tops Artificial Analysis at **59**, but answer accuracy rising 48 to 58 per cent came with the **hallucination rate going 4 to 11**, and time-to-first-token measures **97.5 seconds**. It leads **15 of the 16 tests Google chose**.[5]

**SOURCES** 1 Anthropic, PBC, Form S-1 filed 26 October 2026, accession 0001628280-26-067168, and the company's EDGAR filing index — **the 14.17MB document exceeded the fetch limit, so it was downloaded whole, stripped and searched on this desk**; the $637.0bn sum and the three rival totals are this magazine's arithmetic on the filing's own named commitments. 2 The same filing's summary consolidated financial data and operating metrics, cross-checked line by line against Fortune's independent reading of 26 October. 3 Hacker News item 50242939, by signed username; **Reddit returned 403, and api.github.com is outside this session's scope, so GitHub was read as HTML.** 4 Burry via Stocktwits, 27 October — **single-sourced; his original post could not be reached**, and the one figure that fails is flagged above. 5 Google's own announcement and Artificial Analysis' measurements, both 28 October; the export rules from Reuters copy read through a syndicating site, **reuters.com having refused this desk**.

TECHNOLOGY · THE EXPERT CACHE

# llama.cpp v0.8.0 ships an MoE cache change whose regression fix was closed unmerged

*Georgi Gerganov is counting down to v1.0.0 by early November; on one Ryzen 9 9950X3D the new cache took GLM 5.3 Flash from about 15 tokens a second to 12.5.*

The ggml-org project released **llama.cpp v0.8.0** at 12:47 on **Wednesday 28 October**, five days behind Georgi Gerganov's published schedule. It adds LiquidAI's LFM3 and d1 families, DeepSeek V4.1 Flash, a `/v1/realtime` endpoint and a `POST /tts` route — and one break that will bite tonight: **the command line now requires `--model` or `-hf`**. Scripts that relied on a default fail on upgrade.[1]

The item to read before upgrading is quieter. On 19 October the project merged **PR #30637**, replacing the plain least-recently-used cache for mixture-of-experts weights held in host memory with a 50/50 segmented one. Its author measured gains of **1 to 5 per cent** on two machines. A user running GLM 5.3 Flash on a Ryzen 9 9950X3D with an RTX PRO 4500 measured the opposite: **about 15 tokens a second falling to 12.5** at a 4,500MiB cache.[2]

The author accepted it, diagnosed it as small caches churning, and wrote the fix — **PR #30848**, which on that same machine restored **15.55 tokens a second at 4,500MiB and 17.30 at 7,000**. He then **closed it unmerged on 27 October**. The release shipped the next day with the new cache and without the fallback. If your experts live in host memory on a tight budget, v0.8.0 may be slower than v0.7.0, and the patch that would fix it exists.[2]

Meanwhile the model everyone wanted is here and half-working. **LFM3-1.7B** — 1.73bn parameters, 24 layers, **256K** context, sixteen languages — ships a quantisation-aware 4-bit build at **0.98 GiB**, confirming the figure this magazine printed yesterday. Its real advantage is the cache: a full 128K KV costs **1.6GB** against **4.3GB** for Qwen3.5-4B. But llama.cpp issue **#31328**, opened 28 October, reports that **any** `response_format` fails with an empty grammar stack — structured output, which is most of what a small agent model is for.[3]

## *"The model will produce garbage output."*

### THE CHATTER · A DUMB BUT FAST SCOUT

On Hacker News, **jakswa** posted the only hardware numbers anyone has offered for LFM3: **212 tokens a second decoding and about 8,500 prefilling** at full context on a Radeon RX 7900 XT with 20GB. His verdict on the output is less flattering — a **"dumb but fast scout, findings should be verified"**. **samstevens** was blunter on scope: "definitely would not recommend using it for SWE-style tasks", which is also what Liquid's own model card says. **syntaxing** had the home-lab use in mind: "Really hoping 1.7B is good enough" for Home Assistant.[4]

### THE SCEPTIC · A FIX OPEN SINCE JUNE

This magazine corrected itself yesterday on the vLLM prefix-cache bug: the issue is **#55766**, not the number No. 145 printed. It is **still open**, and so is its fix. **PR #47123**, which stops a short final prefill being misclassified as speculative decode, was opened on **30 June 2026** and remains unapproved four months and four minor releases later. Its author's own summary of the consequence: without it **"the model will produce garbage output"**. A user reported the bug alive on **v0.32.0** as recently as 24 October. Until it lands, set `cudagraph_mode=PIECEWISE` or use a per-request cache salt.[5]

**4 months**

HOW LONG THE FIX FOR VLLM'S HYBRID-MODEL PREFIX-CACHE CORRUPTION HAS SAT OPEN AND UNAPPROVED ON GITHUB[5]

**Ollama shipped LFM3 to Apple only.** Version **0.40.12**, 27 October, listed the family but ran `lfm3` and `d1:2b` on Apple hardware alone. Four issues were filed and closed within a day, including one Linux user who got "unknown model architecture" from Hugging Face and "this model requires MLX support" from Ollama's own registry. **v0.40.13-rc0**, 28 October, fixes the GGUF path.[6]

**SOURCES** 1 The v0.8.0 release notes and discussion #30566 on github.com, read 28 October. 2 Pull requests #30637 and #30848 and their comment threads, with the reporting user's figures as he posted them. 3 The LFM3-1.7B model card and GGUF file listing on Hugging Face — **note the listing is in decimal GB; 1.05GB is 0.98 GiB** — Liquid's own launch post, and llama.cpp issue #31328. 4 Hacker News item 50262229, by signed username; **Reddit refused this desk again.** 5 vLLM issue #55766 and pull request #47123, both open as read on 28 October. 6 Ollama's release notes and the four issues it drew; NVIDIA's own model announcement. **api.github.com is outside this session's scope, so every GitHub fact here was read as HTML from the page itself.**

THE KIT · THE SIGMA FP2

# Sigma ships the 376g fp2 on 11 November at $2,199, still without IBIS

*Richard Butler of DPReview notes the partially stacked sensor still syncs flash at 1/50sec; the local distributor is already running the hero banner, with no Singapore price behind it.*

Sigma announced the **fp2** on **Thursday 23 October**, opened pre-orders the same day and ships on **11 November** at **US$2,199** for the body, or US$2,749 with either the EVF-21 viewfinder or the 50mm F2 DG lens. It is a 24.5-megapixel full-frame camera weighing **376g** bare and 460g loaded — which Sigma calls the world's smallest full-frame body, footnoted "as of October 2026".[1]

The new part is a **partially stacked CMOS** sensor, and the question it exists to answer is rolling shutter. The fp2 has **no mechanical shutter at all**: everything is electronic, to a maximum of 1/25,600sec, at 20 frames a second. **Richard Butler** of DPReview read the specification and found the tell — flash sync is still limited to **1/50sec**, and "that 1/50 second rolling shutter rate will continue to limit the range of photography the FP2 can turn its hand to". Battery life rises to a CIPA **370** shots from the original's 280.[2]

Against that sit the things it does that nothing else this size does: **12-bit Apple ProRes RAW** internally, 6K to 59.94fps, L-Log, **about 70GB** of built-in storage, and recording to a portable SSD over USB. Sigma claims up to **14.1 stops** in 4K L-Log, a design figure rather than a measured one. **No independent laboratory has yet published a readout time or a dynamic-range measurement**; Butler says plainly he had "not had a lot of chance to use the FP2".[2]

### THE CHATTER · SMALL IS NOT FREE

The Hacker News thread took **58 points and 88 comments** in a day, and the objection is consistent. **freetime2**: "I don't really see the point of making a camera body this small if you have to sacrifice on things like IBIS" — and, on the first generation, "the camera overheated after 33 minutes when recording 4k60p." **9x39** is agnostic on the fix: "the partial stacked sensor might reduce the jello effect, might not." For the defence, **porphyra**: "when it comes to the pareto frontier of small size versus full frame image quality, this is it."[3]

### THE SCEPTIC · FIXED A LOT, NOT THE HANDLING

**Alex Cooke** of Fstoppers, who asked whether Sigma fixed enough: "a camera with no mechanical shutter and no in-body stabilization". The internal storage "is fast, though not fast enough for raw video", and "you can't record to internal memory and the SD card simultaneously". There is "still no Wi-Fi or Bluetooth, so getting files onto your phone means plugging in a cable". On handheld footage: "A little tilt in vertical lines still shows up on very quick pans... The missing in-body stabilization hurts most here." And in the hand it is "solid but not comfortable", with "small buttons" that "can feel fiddly".[4]

**1/50 sec**

FLASH SYNC ON A PARTIALLY STACKED SENSOR — THE ONLY PUBLISHED PROXY FOR A READOUT SPEED NOBODY HAS YET MEASURED[2]

## ALSO ON THIS DESK

**Samsung published the rating it had withheld.** This magazine noted yesterday that the Galaxy Buds On carried an **IP54** claim Samsung had not published. It is now in the spec table — **IP54, earbuds only, the case unrated**. The clip-on open-ear buds went on sale in South Korea on **27 October at KRW 299,000**, with US availability reported at **$229** in early November. **Still no Singapore price: samsung.com/sg does not list the product at all.**[5]

**Pixii is being liquidated.** The court at Besançon converted the digital-rangefinder maker's case to *liquidation judiciaire* on **22 July**, with operations permitted only to 31 July. Retailers still list the Pixii Max at **$4,499** and the Plus at $2,799, and no statement on warranty, repair or support has appeared.[5]

**SOURCES** 1 Sigma's own fp2 product page for every specification and the weight — **it carries neither price nor ship date**, which come from DPReview, Camera Jabber and Imaging Resource, all three agreeing. 2 Richard Butler's initial review at DPReview, 23 October, including his own caveat on how little he had used it. 3 Hacker News item 50211780, by signed username; **Reddit refused this desk.** 4 Alex Cooke, Fstoppers, 24 October. 5 Samsung's specification table as reproduced by two outlets — **Samsung's own pages returned 404 and 503** — plus DPReview on Pixii and on the Instax. **Singapore: the distributor's own site runs the fp2 banner with no price; Alan Photo, TK Foto and Cathay Photo list none either.**

THE GOOD LIFE · THE UNMEASURED FLAGSHIP

# Audio-Technica's ATH-AWX7000 sells at $3,799 with no published measurement

*Three reviews landed between 23 and 28 October and all are listening notes; Major HiFi states it outright — "Measurements: None" — and the Kiso cypress flagship has no Singapore price or stockist.*

Audio-Technica's closed-back flagship, the **ATH-AWX7000**, debuted at the Paris Audio Video Show on **23 October** and has been on sale worldwide since, at **US$3,799**, €3,799 and £3,299. The housings are **Kiso cypress** hand-finished in **Echizen lacquer**, on a magnesium frame with machined aluminium sliders, deep-navy *kachi-iro* metalwork and Japanese deerskin on the headband and pads. It weighs about **353g** and runs a **58mm** driver with a new hybrid matrix diaphragm.[1]

Every number in that paragraph after the price is the maker's. Impedance **48 ohms**, sensitivity **97dB per milliwatt**, response **5Hz to 50kHz** — all manufacturer-stated, none independently checked. This magazine held that point open yesterday and it has not closed: five days into worldwide sale, **no laboratory measurement of this headphone exists anywhere this desk can reach**. Major HiFi prints the admission in its own specification block: **"Measurements: None. The review is based on subjective listening."** Audio Science Review's headphone forum carries no thread on it at all.[2]

Where it was built is also unsettled: one outlet says Tokyo, another the Naruse factory, and **Audio-Technica's own site refused every region this desk tried**, so there is no maker page to adjudicate — or to carry a price. For scale, the open-back sibling ATH-ADX7000 is **$3,499** and 78g lighter; Dan Clark's Stealth is $3,999 and Focal's Stellia $2,999. The flagship Audio-Technica that actually showed its face in Singapore this year was the ADX7000, at the Asia expo in June. **For this one there is no Singapore price and no named local stockist.**[3]

> *"Vocals can sound hollow and distant."*

### THE CHATTER · A NEGATIVE FINDING, HONESTLY REPORTED

There is no owner thread. Head-Fi served a bot-check on four attempts; Audiogon, Headphonesty and WhatsBestForum returned 403; Audio Science Review's search came back empty and its headphone index carries nothing; Hacker News has no Audio-Technica story since January 2025; Reddit refused, as it has all year. **StereoNET's forum search did work, and returned zero posts on this headphone.** Five days after a flagship goes on sale in Europe, America and Japan at the price of a decent watch, the enthusiast internet has not yet said a word about it that this desk can read.[2]

### THE SCEPTIC · THE VOICE IS IN THE WRONG PLACE

**Alex Schiffer** of Major HiFi, the sharpest of the three: "Vocals can sound hollow and distant", "consistently feel far away, never taking a commanding stance in the mix"; "Transients are a bit slow"; the upper treble is "quite biting at times". His cons list reads, in full, "Pricey." The tuning "comes with some distinct quirks" that "make it harder to recommend universally". **Audio46**, which also sells the thing, agrees from the other side: "For people sensitive to bass, you may find the AWX7000 to be a bit overwhelming", and on vocal-led tracks the reproduction "did sound a bit odd".[2]

**5–50,000Hz**

AUDIO-TECHNICA'S CLAIMED FREQUENCY RESPONSE — A MAKER'S FIGURE NO INDEPENDENT LAB HAS CHECKED, FIVE DAYS INTO WORLDWIDE SALE[1]

### OBJECTS WORTH THE INK

**Oris publishes a Singapore price, which is rarer than it should be.** The Aquis Date Kelp Forest, announced **21 October** and limited to **1,000** numbered pieces, is **USD 2,950** on Oris's American store and **SGD 3,900** on its Singapore one, with the cart live — a **32 per cent** premium on a straight conversion before GST. A 41.5mm steel case, ceramic bezel, calibre 733-1 at 41 hours, 300m, and a dial 3D-printed to imitate swaying kelp. **Oris names no charity partner on the page.**[4]

**SOURCES** 1 Specifications and price from ecoustics and Basic Tutorials, whose tables agree; **audio-technica.com returned 403 or 404 in every region, so no maker page was read and the two outlets disagree on the factory — Tokyo against Naruse — which is printed as unsettled.** 2 Alex Schiffer at Major HiFi, 23 and 28 October, including his own "Measurements: None"; Audio46, 23 October, **which is a retailer that sells the headphone**; the empty-search result at Audio Science Review and StereoNET. 3 Comparative prices from ecoustics' own table; the Singapore absence confirmed at stereo.com.sg and treoo.com, neither of which lists it. 4 Oris's own US and Singapore storefronts, read 28 October; Gear Patrol on the Lange, the Girard-Perregaux and the Sinn. **WatchUSeek now returns 402 Payment Required, so no watch-forum sentiment appears on this page.**

SCREEN & SOUND · THE WEEKEND CHART

# Warner Bros. opened Clayface at number one with $24.0m from 3,458 theatres

*Critics gave the body-horror Batman spin-off a Metascore of 59 from 45 reviews; the 2,500 verified viewers behind its 94 per cent Popcornmeter disagreed by 35 points.*

Warner Bros. and DC Studios opened **Clayface** wide on **23 October** and took the weekend: **$24,002,731** from **3,458** theatres, a per-screen average of **$6,941**, with both Box Office Mojo and The Numbers posting identical figures. James Watkins directed, from a Mike Flanagan and Hossein Amini screenplay, on a budget reported between **$30m and $44m**; Tom Rhys Harries plays Matt Hagen, with Naomi Ackie, and Aaron Paul turns up uncredited. It runs 108 minutes and is rated R.[1]

The interesting number is the disagreement. **Metacritic: 59** from 45 critics — 24 positive, 18 mixed, 3 negative. **Rotten Tomatoes: 77 per cent** from 190 reviews, against a **Popcornmeter of 94** from more than 2,500 verified ratings. Rolling Stone scored it **20** and compared it to "eating a handful of Play-Doh, and twice as flavorless". The Associated Press gave it 75 for its "charming low-rent vibe". CinemaScore reportedly came back **A−**.[2]

Below it, two better stories. A24's **You Can See Everything** did the thing films almost never do and went **up 25 per cent in its second weekend**, to $19.5m on an expansion from 855 to 2,655 theatres — and its **$7,344** per screen beat the number one. Paramount's **Street Fighter** did the ordinary thing instead, falling **72.1 per cent** on the same 3,575 sites, from $8,608 a screen to $2,402.[1]

> *"After a tortuously long backstory, 'Clayface' finally gets to the obvious."*

### THE CHATTER · A THIRTY-FIVE POINT GAP, AND NO THREAD TO READ

There is no audience voice on this page and the reason should be printed rather than papered over: Letterboxd's review pages returned 403, Reddit refused as usual, and the trade press that covers opening weekends refused too. What is readable is the split itself — **59 from 45 critics against 94 from 2,500-plus verified viewers**, with Metacritic's own user score at **7.5** from 188. That is a thirty-five-point gap between the people paid to watch it and the people who bought tickets, and it is the whole audience read this desk can honestly offer.[2]

### THE SCEPTIC · GOTHAM IS NOT IN THE FILM

**Rick Bentley** of KGET, grading it C−: "After a tortuously long backstory, 'Clayface' finally gets to the obvious." **Angelica Jade Bastién** in New York magazine, mixed and precise: "I had a fun time watching Clayface, but it doesn't offer up any lasting cinematic pleasures." USA Today, at 50, lands the structural complaint — the film "doesn't utilize Gotham itself as a character", which for a Batman property is the one thing the setting was supposed to buy. **A live conflict worth naming: the film's own Wikipedia page gives its worldwide gross as $47.4m in the body and $50.8m in the infobox.**[2]

### ALSO ON THIS DESK

**Fontaines D.C. took the UK albums chart with the format nobody was supposed to buy.** *Dopamine Chamber* entered at number one on **70,105** chart units — **37,501 of them vinyl**, 14,235 CDs, 1,796 cassettes, 1,479 downloads and 15,094 streaming equivalents. It outsold the next eight albums in the top ten combined, and is the fastest-selling Irish studio album in Britain since Snow Patrol in 2011. XL's **Ben Beardsworth**: "We are lucky that it's happened on our watch." Hot Press scored it **9/10**.[3]

**Klara, revisited.** This magazine reported Taika Waititi's *Klara and the Sun* at $198 a screen and no positive notices of 26. Going wide on 23 October it took **$701,059 from 880 theatres** — about **$796** a screen, four times the earlier figure — and Rotten Tomatoes now reads **25 per cent** from 83 reviews with a Popcornmeter of 77. Rendy Jones, at 1.5 out of 5: "I miss when Taika movies had some Weightiti to them."[1]

**SOURCES** 1 Box Office Mojo and The Numbers, weekend 43 (23–25 October), read 28 October — both carry identical grosses, theatre counts and averages; **they differ on Wildwood's theatre count, 2,817 against 2,596**, which is noted rather than resolved. 2 Metacritic and Rotten Tomatoes, read 28 October, with the individual critics quoted from their entries there; **the CinemaScore grade reaches this desk only through Wikipedia and is flagged as such**. 3 The Official Charts Company's own chart page and news item, with the format breakdown from Music Week citing the chart company; Hot Press for the review. **Billboard now returns 402 Payment Required, Metacritic's music pages and AlbumOfTheYear returned 403, and Pitchfork is unreachable — so no aggregate score is printed for this album and no negative review of it appears here, because none could be read.**

THE FAMILY DESK · THE PHONE BAN EVIDENCE

# Iceland banned phones in 22 schools and JAMA found no mental-health gain

*Across 23,938 adolescents and seven outcomes, not one result cleared the study's own threshold — and Singapore widened its own ban to recess and CCAs in January.*

A difference-in-differences study of **23,938** adolescent observations across **70** Icelandic schools, published in *JAMA Network Open* on **27 October**, compared the **22** that adopted a whole-school phone ban between 2018 and 2023 with the 48 that restricted phones in lessons only. It measured depression, anxiety, hostility, mental well-being, peer support, bullying and daily screen use. Against a Bonferroni threshold of **P < .002**, **not one outcome cleared it.**[1]

Read the direction, not just the significance. Depressive symptoms moved **+0.65** after the policy, mental well-being **−0.52**, hostility +0.23 — every estimate that moved at all moved against the ban, and none of them survives correction. Reported social-media use did not fall. The authors' own conclusion is that bans "implemented in isolation may be insufficient to improve adolescent mental health at the population level", while allowing they may still help classroom outcomes the study did not measure.[1]

The larger test agrees and adds a cost. A pre-registered American study of **nearly 5,000 schools** using Yondr lockable pouches — by Hunt Allcott, Thomas Dee, Angela Duckworth and colleagues — found pouches do suppress phone use, and that **test-score effects are bounded within about 0.007 student-level standard deviations**. High schools gained a little, mostly in maths; **middle schools came out slightly negative**. In the adoption year, suspensions rose about **15 per cent** before the effect faded.[2]

This matters here because Singapore has just done it. From **January 2026**, MOE broadened its guidelines beyond lessons: smartphones and smartwatches "will not be allowed during school hours, including recess, co-curricular activities" and the rest, stored in lockers or bags. The ministry's stated reason is displacement — screen use "has been shown to displace important activities such as sleep, physical activity and social interactions". **That is close to the Icelandic intervention, and the best two studies of it report roughly nothing at the population level.**[3]

> ***"Bans implemented in isolation may be insufficient to improve adolescent mental health."***

### THE CHATTER · THE PARENTS DID IT THEMSELVES

The Hacker News thread on the American study ran to **216 comments**. **kelnos**: "Frankly, I think it's absolutely insane that they were *ever* allowed." **Aurornis**, more measured: "middle and high schools deserve some extra boundaries to get the ball rolling on learning how to exist without a phone" — and, puncturing a staple of the discourse, that the prefrontal cortex finishes at 25 "has been repeated for decades but it's essentially a myth". The most useful line is domestic, from **rootusrootus** on a household charging station: "Before bed, all of those devices get put there. Including me and my wife's phones."[4]

### THE SCEPTIC · SHE IS INSIDE THE STUDY

**Candice Odgers** of UC Irvine is a co-author of the Icelandic null — and has been the field's leading sceptic of the panic for years. Her line in *Nature*: **"Most data are correlative"**, and young people "who already have mental-health problems use such platforms more often" than their peers. She notes a 72-country analysis finding "no consistent or measurable associations between well-being and the roll-out of social media globally", and that brain imaging shows "no evidence of drastic changes". She names the rivals: hardship, guns, violence, discrimination, opioids. **The sceptic is not shouting at this paper; she helped write it.** General guidance, not medical advice.[5]

**0 of 7**

OUTCOMES IN THE ICELANDIC PHONE-BAN STUDY THAT CLEARED ITS OWN SIGNIFICANCE THRESHOLD, ACROSS 23,938 OBSERVATIONS IN 70 SCHOOLS[1]

**ALSO ON THIS DESK**

**SOURCES** 1 Bonilla Aparicio and colleagues, *JAMA Network Open* 2026;9(10):e2640893, published online 27 October — effect sizes, intervals, thresholds and the authors' own limitations read at the journal. 2 Allcott, Baron, Dee, Duckworth, Gentzkow and Jacob, NBER working paper 35132, April 2026, revised September — read from the authors' own PDF. 3 MOE's press release of 30 November 2025 and its parliamentary reply of 26 February 2026, **both read directly from the ministry's own pages**. 4 Hacker News item 46124179, by signed username; **Reddit and four parenting forums refused this desk, which is why no parent's voice appears above except that one.** 5 Candice Odgers in *Nature*, 29 March 2024; her authorship of the 27 October paper is on its own author list. 6 *JAMA Pediatrics*, 6 October 2026. **Three widely recirculated "October 2026" studies were checked and dropped: all three are 2025 or early-2026 papers re-dated by an aggregator.**

THE FAMILY DESK · THE LAST FIVE MINUTES

# JAMA Pediatrics ties each post-10pm phone minute to 0.87 minutes of later sleep

*Dimitri Christakis and colleagues sensed 7,591 nights with a phone app and a Fitbit rather than asking; the worst of it sits in the final five minutes, and MOE's lever is a 10.30pm cutoff.*

An intensive longitudinal study inside the ABCD cohort, published in JAMA *Pediatrics* on **19 October**, followed **425** adolescents across **7,591 person-nights** to February 2024. Phone use was **passively sensed** by an app, not self-reported; sleep came from a Fitbit. Within each adolescent, measured against their own average, every extra minute of use after 10pm pushed sleep onset **0.87 minutes later** (95% CI 0.84 to 0.90), woke them **0.37** later, and took **0.43** minutes off the night.[1]

The sharper finding is about timing, not volume. Sustained wakefulness after falling asleep was worst when the phone was used in the **final five minutes** before sleep onset — **0.74 extra minutes awake** (0.50 to 0.98) — and was negligible by twenty minutes before. On nights with above-average use after 10pm these adolescents fell asleep a mean **64.73 minutes later** and slept **20.05 minutes less**. Print the spread too: the standard deviations, **50.95 and 49.42**, are larger than the means.[1]

Singapore's lever is set a few minutes earlier than the damage. From **January 2026** the default sleep hour on secondary-school Personal Learning Devices moved from 11.00pm to **10.30pm**. MOE's own monitoring, in a parliamentary reply of **5 August**, reports that Primary 5 and Secondary 3 students averaged **7 hours** of sleep on school days in the 2025 survey, "a slight increase compared to 2023". **A device that sleeps at 10.30 and a phone in the hand at 10.29 are not the same intervention**, and this study is about the second one.[2]

For scale on what sits underneath: a nationally representative analysis of **15,730** American adolescents **aged 12 to 20** — a band that does contain a twelve-year-old — published on 12 October, screened **16.8 per cent** at moderate or severe anxiety on the GAD-7, girls at more than double boys at every level. Among those with severe symptoms, **41.2 per cent** had received no mental-health treatment in the past year.[3]

### THE CHATTER · WHAT A HOUSEHOLD DOES WITHOUT A MINISTRY

Parent forums refused this desk and Reddit refused it again, so there is one honest voice available and it is the same Hacker News thread as the facing page — where **rootusrootus** described the arrangement his household arrived at on its own: a charging station in a common room, and "Before bed, all of those devices get put there. Including me and my wife's phones." It is, almost exactly, the intervention this study implies: not an hour, but the last few minutes, and not the child alone.[4]

### THE SCEPTIC · THE INSTRUMENT CANNOT BE RESCORED

Seven days before the sleep paper, in the **same journal and the same cohort**, Shalom Jaffe and Eleanor McGlinchey of Fairleigh Dickinson published a research letter comparing ABCD's wearable-derived sleep durations against published paediatric norms. Their objection goes to the instrument: consumer wearables can measure many nights, but their estimates come from **"proprietary algorithms that researchers cannot always inspect or rescore". Their actual divergence figures are paywalled and are not printed here.** The falsification test is clean: run it with independently scored actigraphy, or establish that the tween who cannot sleep is not simply the one who picks up the phone. General guidance, not medical advice.[5]

**64.73 min**

HOW MUCH LATER THESE ADOLESCENTS FELL ASLEEP ON NIGHTS OF ABOVE-AVERAGE POST-10PM PHONE USE — WITH A STANDARD DEVIATION OF 50.95[1]

**ALSO ON THIS DESK**

**SOURCES** 1 Zhao, Hale and Christakis, *JAMA Pediatrics*, published online 19 October 2026 — key points and the full structured abstract read at the journal; **the limitations section is paywalled and nothing is attributed to it.** 2 MOE's parliamentary reply of 5 August 2026 and its press release of 30 November 2025, both read from the ministry's own pages. 3 Bommersbach and colleagues, *JAMA Pediatrics*, 12 October 2026; the concussion trial, same journal, 19 October. 4 Hacker News item 46124179, by signed username; **Reddit and the parenting forums refused.** 5 Jaffe and McGlinchey, research letter, *JAMA Pediatrics*, 12 October 2026 — **the letter has no abstract and its figures are paywalled to October 2027, so only its stated objection is printed.** The Bigman quotation above is from press coverage of the study, not from the paper.

THE MACRO DESK · THE OCTOBER HOLD

# The Fed held at 3.75 per cent; Cook and Hammack both voted to hike

*Kevin Warsh's committee split ten to two the day before the September inflation print it says it is waiting for — and the market moved to an 82.6 per cent chance of a December rise.*

The Federal Open Market Committee voted **ten to two** on **Wednesday 28 October** to hold the federal funds target at **3.75 to 4 per cent**. Governor **Lisa Cook** and Cleveland's **Beth Hammack** dissented — both for a quarter-point *rise*. The statement runs three paragraphs, carries no forward guidance, and this meeting publishes no projections. It calls activity "expanding at a strong pace" and inflation "elevated", then declares rather than forecasts: **"The Committee will deliver price stability."**[1]

The operative phrase is "the accumulation of more information", and the timing gives it away. The advance third-quarter GDP figure and the **September personal consumption expenditures price index** — the Fed's own inflation measure — land at **8:30am in Washington on 29 October**, the morning after the vote. **The committee held without having seen September's inflation.**[1]

The tape did not read it as a dovish hold. The ten-year rose **6bp to 5.05 per cent** while the two-year *fell* 3bp — a bear steepener of 9bp on a day the policy rate did not move — and the long end is kinked, **twenty-year 5.41 against thirty-year 5.37**. The S&P 500 rose 0.28 per cent the same session, so bonds hedged nothing. Behind it is oil: Brent near **$114.10**, up **77.4 per cent in a year**, with Australia's print already at **4.3 per cent**.[2]

**THE BOARD · AT WEDNESDAY'S CLOSE**

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| **US 10-year** | 5.05% | ▲ 6bp |
| **US 2-year** | 4.67% | ▼ 3bp |
| **VWRA** | $191.64 | ▲ 0.18% |
| **AGGU** | $5.79 | — |
| **Brent** | $114.10 | ▲ 0.19% |
| **Gold** | $4,081.20 | ▲ 0.16% |
| **Bitcoin** | $81,350 | ▲ 0.67% |
| **USD/SGD** | 1.2805 | — |
| **STI** | 5,397.91 | ▲ 0.02% |

**VWRA and AGGU close in London at 16:30 GMT; the statement landed at 18:00** — both prints predate the Fed. Bitcoin is intraday.[2]

**THE CHATTER · CAN RATES REACH THE AI TRADE**

The best exchange of the day happened across a podium. **Bill Ackman** posted that higher rates might not reduce demand for artificial intelligence. Warsh answered from the press conference: **"Interest rates get in the cracks"** — and, asked whether rates matter for AI investment, **"I believe they do."** With no projections and no guidance, **Gregory Daco** of EY-Parthenon notes, Warsh is "the one that is guiding markets' interpretation".[3]

**THE SCEPTIC · AGAINST AN 82.6 PER CENT CONSENSUS**

The market has moved to an **82.6 per cent** implied probability of a December rise, from 78.3 a day earlier, and Goldman Sachs Asset Management's **Kay Haigh** expects the Fed to "resume rate hikes in December". **Seema Shah** of Principal reads the same text the other way: the "Fed has time on its side" and "room to wait for more data". **Market explanation, not investment advice.**[4]

**0.50**

THREE-YEAR STOCK–BOND CORRELATION AT 30 SEPTEMBER; ABOVE 5 PER CENT INFLATION IT HAS AVERAGED 0.46 AND BEEN POSITIVE IN EVERY MONTH MEASURED[5]

**What it means for the four. VWRA** is winning the argument between earnings and a 5 per cent discount rate, but its London close predates the statement. **Global bonds** are flat because the damage sits in the twenty-to-thirty-year sector. **Gold** at $4,081 is held up by Hormuz and held down by real yields — not making highs during an oil shock, which is the tell. **Bitcoin**, 28 per cent below its high, faces tightening policy, bill-only balance-sheet growth and a 4–5 per cent risk-free alternative at once.

HIGHER-FOR-LONGER ENERGY-LED BEAR STEEPENER[5]

**SOURCES** 1 The FOMC statement and implementation note of 28 October, **read in full from the Federal Reserve's own PDF, whose text was extracted on this desk**; release schedules from the Bureau of Economic Analysis and the Bureau of Labor Statistics. 2 Yields from the US Treasury's own daily curve file for 28 October; every other level read at its own quote page the same day; the Australian figure from its statistical agency. **Brent carried a conflict — one feed showed 110.44 against two others at 114.10 and 114.13 — so the agreeing pair is printed and the outlier discarded.** 3 Warsh's press conference as logged live, 28 October. 4 Shah and Haigh the same day; **the December probability is single-sourced, the exchange's own site having returned 503.** 5 Correlation figures from ALPS Advisors, 27 October, and Apollo, 22 October — **the latter is also selling the alternative, so the arithmetic is used and the prescription is not.**

THE RABBIT HOLE · MARQUETRY

# Ivor Bagley won the 2026 Rosebowl with a Dalí cut from wood veneer

*The Marquetry Society has run its exhibition since 1952 and ranks entrants in ten classes; take its top trophy and you are promoted to Premier and made a Fellow, permanently.*

Marquetry is a picture made entirely of wood. Not carved — assembled, from leaves of veneer about **0.56 to 0.61mm** thick, each piece cut to fit its neighbour and glued down onto a board as one skin. The craft's own governing body is precise about what it is not: **inlay** sets pieces into solid wood, **intarsia** assembles solid blocks. Marquetry covers the whole surface. Geometric marquetry has its own name, **parquetry**, and its own trophy.[1]

There are two ways in, and choosing between them is the only expensive decision in the hobby. The **window method** cuts a hole in a single sheet, uses the hole as the template for the next piece, drops it in and tapes it — so the picture builds in front of you and you can change your mind. The knife is tilted, a **double bevel**, so each piece wedges in and hides the saw gap. The alternative is **boulle** or packet cutting: stack several veneers, saw through the lot, and every layer yields interlocking parts — the motif and its own negative at once.[1]

The enemy of the second method is the **kerf**, which the Society's glossary defines as "the waste removed when a saw cuts through a veneer pad". You cannot get it back. That is what the **chevalet de marqueterie** — the donkey — exists to beat: a foot-clamped, seated sawing machine whose parallel rods, as one owner puts it, ensure "that the blade is always perpendicular to the packet". Roubo illustrated one in 1769; an earlier form appears in a Paris book of 1676.[2]

What hooks people is that the first version costs almost nothing. The Society's beginner page has you make the cutting board from a plywood offcut faced with a vinyl floor tile. UK membership is **£30** a year, an A3 mat **£7.98**, a craft knife and three blades **£2.28**. The hard part is not equipment. **marguetry**, on a woodworking forum after weeks of four-hour days: "Problem is my index finger is getting very sore." The reply: "Four hours a day…are you crippled yet?"[3]

### THE CHATTER · A SOCIETY THAT WILL NOT COUNT ITSELF

The Marquetry Society, founded **1952**, publishes a quarterly, *The Marquetarian*, and lists **24 named UK clubs** from Bexley to Thurrock. It also publishes a free textbook: some **180 pages** of tutorials, a glossary, a suppliers' directory and national galleries for a dozen countries. What it does not publish, anywhere this desk could find, is **how many members it has**. Its most recent operational news was that PayPal closed its account in October 2023.[4]

### THE SCEPTIC · NOBODY AGREES WHAT THE MARKET IS

Three research houses, read the same day, price the world veneer market at **US$16.74bn**, **US$20.8bn** and **US$26.4bn** for 2025, with forecast growth of **2.70 against 6.3 per cent** — driven entirely by whether "veneer" means decorative face veneer or all sheet. A fourth says its report is "currently being developed". **So this page prints the range and not a number.** And marquetry is a rounding error inside a rounding error of that market.[5]

**0.56 mm**

STANDARD COMMERCIAL VENEER, ONE FORTY-SECOND OF AN INCH — AGAINST THE 1.5MM SAWN STOCK A PROFESSIONAL USES SO HE CAN WORK THE EDGES LIKE REAL WOOD[1]

### THE LADDER YOU SPEND A LIFETIME CLIMBING

**Class 1 is strictly "one of their first 4 pictures"**, then Secondary, Intermediate, Advanced and Premier; miniatures must be under **12 square inches**, and a miniature applied piece must fit a box **4 by 3 by 3 inches**. **Class 8, "Three Veneers",** allows three leaves, nothing dyed, sand scorching only — an entire competition class exists to prove you can get tone without chemistry.[6]

**SOURCES** 1 The Marquetry Society's own definition, glossary and window-method pages, read 28 October; veneer thicknesses from Veneer Supplies' starter course, and the 1.5mm sawn figure from W. Patrick Edwards' own blog. 2 The Society's glossary on the kerf; Mike Mason on Sawmill Creek, 4 March 2017, on the chevalet's parallel rods; Edwards' own history of the tool for the 1769 and 1676 citations. 3 Membership and tool prices read at the Society and at Axminster on 28 October; the forum exchange from the Fine Woodworking forum, 10 November 2006, by handle. 4 The Society's own site map, clubs list, magazine page and news archive — **it publishes no membership figure on any of them, which is reported here as an absence rather than estimated.** 5 Fortune Business Insights, Persistence Market Research and Future Market Insights, each read at its own page; Grand View Research has no report. 6 The Society's awards definitions, trophies list, judges' rules and 2026 premier-class gallery. **Reddit refused this desk entirely, so every community voice on these three pages comes from Sawmill Creek, Fine Woodworking, WoodWeb or Craftisian.**

The glue argument is three-sided and the camps do not pretend otherwise. The **UK Society's own position is urea formaldehyde** — Cascamite, now sold as Powermite — because it sets hard and fills gaps, pressed in a screw press for a week. Its verdict on the obvious alternative is blunt: PVA "usually stays rubbery and can sink or shrink as it dries", and left too long under pressure it grows **"small blue-black spots"** no sandpaper will remove. Also: **"NEITHER UREA NOR PVA PERFORM WELL UNDER 10°C."**[1]

The American retail orthodoxy agrees about PVA and goes elsewhere: yellow glue "does not dry hard… it stays rubbery and semi-flexible", so the veneer creeps with the seasons and joints open months later. Use a powdered urea resin, or a proprietary cold-press. And the third camp, the conservators, use hide glue for reversibility — with a warning from the trade register that is worth the whole section: **"If you have never used hide glue to hammer veneer, I would not suggest learning it on a marquetry panel."** And, flatly, **"You don't hammer marquetry panels with hide glue."**[1]

The press is simpler than the argument about it. Most veneer adhesives need about **1,300lb per square foot** — roughly nine psi — and a vacuum bag delivers **1,700lb**, evenly. Forum posters name pressing as the barrier to entry, and the numbers say they are wrong: a **Roarockit Thin Air Press kit is US$94.95**, a hand pump and a 20-mil bag with a one-way valve, no compressor and no wiring. The powered ladder above it runs **US$92, 218.50, 316.50, 344.50, 469.50, 509.50 and 649** across seven kits, and most marquetarians never climb past the first rung.[2]

What you cut with splits the same way. The knife is a **Swann-Morton 10A on a No. 3 handle**, and the Society expects you to resharpen it on a stone rather than bin it — rubbing the **back** flat, never the bevel. The saw is a fretsaw, and the one serious hand-cutters buy is a **Knew Concepts**: 3in at US$99, 5in at US$115, 8in at US$139, with swivel blade clamps adding US$10–20, and a titanium birdcage 5in at **US$235**. Its own two price lists disagree on the 8in — US$139 on one page, US$149 on another. Marquetry blades are **US$10.03**.[3]

## THE DONKEY, AND WHY ALMOST NOBODY BUILDS THEM

**W. Patrick Edwards has sold chevalet hardware kits since 2000** — machined sliding mechanism, jaws, bolts, blades and full-scale blueprints, **US$500 plus US$50 shipping**, with the buyer supplying **"about $750 in wood and perhaps 2 weeks"**. His own published economics are the sceptic's best material: **"The value of a complete tool is about $2500… there is not much profit to be made in making them for sale."**[4]

**The Canadian School of French Marquetry publishes the only full ladder**, in Canadian dollars, **"offered as of Fall 2016" and still live in 2026**: pre-cut plywood parts C$400, pre-assembled C$500, solid-wood parts C$650, hardware C$300 — or **C$2,000 for the whole thing, assembled and tested**. On the same site it gives the plans away and says a scratch build **"can be done for around $100 in about 40 hours"**. A US$2,500 tool, a US$500 kit and a US$100 build make identical cuts.[4]

### THE CHATTER · FOUR ARGUMENTS THAT NEVER END

**John Sincerbeaux**, endorsing the chevalet and doubting it in one breath: "I definitely think using a chevalet for Marquetry results in superior results" — then, "I have a hard time wrapping my noggin around cutting with such a huge and archaic device?" **Mike Henderson**, deflating it: a variable-speed scroll saw can "mimic the operation of the chevalet". **Mike Mason**, conceding the real scope: for one-offs with no repeated parts, its advantage "may mostly be ease of use". And on the way in, **barada83**: "I'm a hobbyist with pretty much no budget but I do have a veneer hammer and a lot of hide glue granules" — before hitting the first wall, "how much the seams move when you hit them with a nice amount of wet and warm hide glue".[5]

### THE SCEPTIC · THE PRESS IS THE MONEY PIT, NOT THE SAW

The upgrade treadmill in this craft runs the wrong way round. The object people fetishise — the chevalet — is a one-off purchase that a scratch builder can replicate for a hundred dollars, and the thing they avoid buying, the press, is the one that actually decides whether the panel holds. **A US$94.95 hand-pumped bag delivers the same 1,700lb per square foot as a US$649 auto-cycling pump.** Everything between them buys convenience and noise. The honest reading of the price list is that the craft's equipment ladder is unusually visible — and unusually skippable.[2]

## THE CONSUMABLE, PRICED

**SOURCES** 1 The Marquetry Society's glue article; Veneer Supplies' myths and adhesive guides; WoodWeb's knowledge-base page on veneering marquetry with hide glue, question dated 11 June 2014. 2 Veneer Supplies on pressure and on pressing without a vacuum press; Roarockit's own shop; the seven-kit ladder read at Veneer Supplies, 28 October. 3 The Society's knife page; Knew Concepts' own shop — **its homepage and its all-products page disagree on the 8-inch saw, and both figures are printed; Swann-Morton's own .com now redirects to a domain broker and its UK stockist shows "Price: £" with no figure, so no scalpel price is printed.** 4 Edwards' own blog post of 18 November 2010 — **2010 prices, and current availability is unverified: the school's domain no longer resolves** — and the Canadian School's own price page. 5 Sawmill Creek and the Fine Woodworking forum, by handle, dates as posted. 6 Veneer Supplies' own sheet listings and veneer-information page, read 28 October. 7 The UK authority's CITES guidance; **cites.org returned 403 on every path tried.**

At the top of the craft the prices are published and startling. **Craig Thibodeau** of San Diego, one of the few makers who states a band on his own site, puts a simple custom marquetry side table at **US$5,000 to US$10,000**, a dining table at **US$15,000 to US$25,000**, and mechanical or puzzle furniture at **US$30,000 and up**. **Paul Schürch**, now in Hawai'i, sells a two-video course for **US$60** and mentors at **US$150 an hour** plus travel.[1]

The teaching infrastructure is thinner than the craft's reputation suggests, and this is the week's real finding. The **American School of French Marquetry**, founded in San Diego in 2000, ran week-long classes on eight chevalets. Today **its own domain does not resolve**; its founder's blog has posted seven times since 2020, most recently on **31 December 2024**; and his other site still describes the school without publishing a class date, a fee or a kit price. **No closure has been announced. Equally, no 2025 or 2026 class has been published anywhere this desk could read.**[2]

Where you can still book him is Indiana: the Marc Adams school lists a French marquetry week for **28 September to 2 October 2026** at **US$1,050 plus an US$85 material fee**, capped at eight students by the eight chevalets on site. **That listing could not be opened directly — telephone first.** Nearer home there is nothing: this desk could find **no marquetry, parquetry or veneer course anywhere in Singapore**. The closest are two days in Somerset at £420.[3]

**The craft's own journal published the case against itself. Susana Bartolomé**, writing for the Marquetry Society, on the laser: it cuts "very quickly and with extremely high precision" and lets a maker enter "the commercial market with genuinely reasonable prices". She notes that members "give great importance to the skilful, difficulty, the craft", and that this is an obstacle to her. The purist reply, from **Ron Bowman**: laser work is "easily detected by those involved in the craft with the lay person being easily duped", and "Machines cannot create art".[4]

### THE CHATTER · WHAT IT COSTS AT THREE LEVELS

**A working starter kit is under £100**: membership £30, an A3 mat £7.98, knife and blades £2.28, tape, carbon paper, a veneer pack, and a cutting board you make yourself. **A serious setup runs about US$1,000** — a Knew Concepts five-inch at US$129, a Roarockit press at US$94.95, a hundred square feet of veneer at US$144, and a hotplate and sand. **Over the top is about US$5,400.** A working marquetarian would tell you the first £80 produces ninety per cent of the pictures.[5]

### THE SCEPTIC · WHAT COULD NOT BE FOUND

This desk went looking for the standard admission — that most marquetry sells for less than the hours in it — **and could not find one that anybody actually wrote**. So the honest sceptical case is structural, not quoted: a craft whose national society cannot publish a membership number, whose defining machine is sold from a **ten-year-old price list**, whose most influential teacher has been silent for **twenty-two months**, and whose own journal has printed the argument for its obsolescence. Nothing here is dying. All of it is thin.[6]

**£110**

AN HONEST NINETY-DAY SPEND, MEMBERSHIP INCLUDED — ANYTHING ABOVE IT BEFORE DAY NINETY IS SHOPPING, NOT MARQUETRY[5]

### THE FIRST NINETY DAYS, AND THE SINGAPORE PROBLEM

**Singapore is the hard case, and nobody has written it down.** Veneer is stored at 38–42 per cent humidity; this city sits at roughly double that, year-round. The documented consequences are mould, buckling burl, cold creep on a glue line and a bowed panel if you do not veneer the back. **This desk searched for any Singapore supplier, school, maker or society addressing veneer movement in a tropical climate and found not one.**[7]

### NEXT DESCENTS

**Origami & paper craft** — a near-free deep-skill craft with a complex-model culture and a serious mathematics crossover.

**Gliding & soaring** — engineless cross-country flight, a real licence ladder, and a secondhand market nobody outside it has seen.

**Amateur perfumery** — accords, absolutes and a regulated materials list, argued over by chemists and collectors alike.

**SOURCES** 1 Craig Thibodeau's own site and Paul Schürch's own shop and class pages, read 28 October. 2 The school's domain failed to resolve on repeated attempts; the post count and last date are from the founder's own public blog archive; **no closure is announced and none is asserted here.** 3 The Marc Adams listing is **single-sourced from a search index — its own pages returned 404**; the Singapore absence was checked against Mokko Wood Studio's own course list and four other local workshops, and is reported as a negative finding. 4 Both arguments as published — Bartolomé on the Marquetry Society's own site, Bowman on his blog, 26 October 2007. 5 Every price in the three tiers was read at its own storefront on 28 October. 6 **The absence is the finding: no such quotation exists in anything this desk could open, and none was invented.** The restoration ethic quoted above is W. Patrick Edwards'. 7 Veneer Supplies' storage and myths pages for the humidity figures; **the Singapore gap was searched for specifically and is reported as empty.**

FITNESS · THE STOPWATCH TEST

# Whitehall II finds a wrist accelerometer predicts death no better than a stopwatch

*Across 4,067 people in the Whitehall II cohort and 739 deaths over a median 11.8 years, nine days of sensed walking cadence scored 0.744 against 0.747 for a nurse timing a 2.44-metre walk.*

A prospective study of **4,067** participants in the Whitehall II accelerometer substudy, published in *JAMA Network Open* on **23 October**, followed them a median **11.8 years** to **739 deaths**, setting two ways of measuring walking speed against each other. One was a nurse with a stopwatch timing a **2.44-metre** course, three trials averaged. The other was a **GENEActiv wrist accelerometer worn nine days**, with walking detected in ten-second windows by a machine-learning model and cadence read off it.[1]

Both work. Per standard deviation, clinical walking speed carried a hazard ratio of **0.77** (95% CI 0.71–0.84); median free-living cadence **0.83** (0.77–0.90); the 95th percentile of cadence **0.82**. Per ten steps a minute of higher median cadence, **0.83** (0.76–0.90). These are not small effects, and nothing here says the wearable is wrong.[1]

What it says is that the wearable is not telling you anything new. The discrimination statistics are **0.747** for the stopwatch (0.730–0.764), **0.744** for median sensed cadence (0.726–0.761) and **0.745** for the 95th percentile. The intervals sit on top of one another. The authors tested whether using both together helped, and report that the benefit **was no longer significant after adjusting for health-related factors**. Nine days of continuous wrist data, scored by an algorithm, carries the information already in a two-and-a-half-metre walk down a corridor.[1]

Two cautions before anyone generalises. The cohort's mean age is **69.3**, so the mortality risk is not a mid-forties risk — the transferable claim is about the *metric*, not the number. And the authors are clear that cadence and speed are **not interchangeable**, that there is **no standardised method** for deriving cadence from an accelerometer, and that they had **no validation dataset**. Their own definition of walking is worth knowing: **40 steps a minute** in a ten-second window, per a named open-source model at a named version.[1]

### THE CHATTER · A SILENCE WORTH REPORTING

There is no optimiser argument about this paper, and the absence is the finding. Hacker News has **no story at all** on walking speed, cadence or steps and mortality in the searchable window; queries on Oura, Whoop and wearables through 2026 return product launches and startup pitches, almost all with between zero and three comments. Reddit refused this desk as usual. **The quantified-self community is buying instruments, not arguing about whether the instruments add information** — which is exactly the question this paper answers, and answers unhelpfully.[2]

### THE SCEPTIC · WHAT A WEARABLE IS ACTUALLY FOR

No methodologist has published against this paper — there is no invited commentary and none of the three institutions issued a release — so the dissent here is a named physiologist on the general claim. **Brady Holmer**, writing on wearables as predictors: "There was no prospectively defined 'alert'... Nor do we know if acting on the wearable data would have changed the outcome", and **"These data shouldn't be treated as a do-it-yourself diagnostic system."** His positive account is the useful one: wearables "are particularly good at establishing personal baselines", and the question worth asking is whether your physiology has stepped away from its own baseline "coherently and durably". **General guidance, not medical advice.**[3]

**0.747 / 0.744**

MORTALITY DISCRIMINATION OF A NURSE'S 2.44-METRE STOPWATCH WALK AGAINST NINE DAYS OF WRIST-SENSED CADENCE, IN THE SAME 4,067 PEOPLE[1]

**ALSO ON THIS DESK**

**SOURCES** 1 Haddadj, Danilevicz, Rowlands, van Hees, Landré, Le Faucheur, Singh-Manoux, Mork and Sabia, *JAMA Network Open* 2026;9(10):e2640122, published online 23 October — hazard ratios, intervals, C indices, the walking definition and the authors' own limitations all read at the journal. 2 Hacker News Algolia queries returning zero stories on the subject across the window, with the exact searches recorded on this desk; **Reddit refused for the fourteenth issue running.** 3 Brady Holmer, *Physiologically Speaking*, 2 October 2026. 4 Zhang and colleagues, *JAMA Network Open* 2026;9(10):e2640127, 23 October; **note a reporting discrepancy in the paper itself, 60.26 against 60.62 per cent female among fallers.** 5 Karolinska Institutet's own release, 16 December 2025. **A Mendelian-randomisation paper that would have bolstered the reverse-causation case could not be read at its journal and is not cited as evidence.**

THE DIARY · THE GHIBLI WINDOW

# Gardens by the Bay opens The Story of Studio Ghibli on 18 December

*Tickets are live at S$39 for residents with children aged 3 to 12 at S$29 — and ART SG's two-for-one early bird closes at 11.59pm on 24 November.*

## SINGAPORE

BOOK NOW · PLAN AHEAD

**1–30 Nov** — **Soundtracks 2026**
ESPLANADE · 22 EVENTS: ANISONG, GAME MUSIC, MOVIE MUSICALS, K-SOUNDTRACKS · **EVERY LISTED EVENT FREE**

**12 Nov–27 Dec** — ★ ***Monkey Goes West* · Wild Rice**
NGEE ANN KONGSI THEATRE, FUNAN · S$50–95 PREVIEWS, **S$60–120 FRI–SUN** · AGES 5 UP · RELAXED PERFORMANCE 20 DEC

**18 Nov–6 Dec** — ***Eureka Day* · Singapore Repertory Theatre**
KC ARTS CENTRE · S$48–78, **YOUTH UNDER 25 S$28** · **ADVISORY: MATURE CONTENT AND COARSE LANGUAGE**

**20–29 Nov** — **Kalaa Utsavam · 25th edition**
ESPLANADE · 40 EVENTS, **SIX OR MORE FREE** · FROM S$29

**18 Dec–4 Jul** — ★ **The Story of Studio Ghibli**
GARDENS BY THE BAY, WEST LAWN, 10AM–7PM · **RESIDENT ADULT S$39, CONCESSION S$29** (3–12 AND 65+); STANDARD S$43–55 · EARLY BIRD TO 17 DEC · **ORGANISER-SOURCED; THE VENUE'S OWN CALENDAR LISTS NOTHING**

**21–24 Jan** — ★ **ART SG 2027**
MARINA BAY SANDS EXPO · VERNISSAGE 21 JAN · **TWO-FOR-ONE ADULT S$40–44 UNTIL 24 NOV, 11.59PM**; USUAL S$80–88 · **UNDER-16S FREE WITH A TICKETED ADULT**

**13–18 Apr** — **Bruno Mars · The Romantic Tour, four nights**
NATIONAL STADIUM, 2027 · **ALL THREE PRESALE WINDOWS AND GENERAL SALE CLOSED IN SEPTEMBER** · VENUE STILL LISTS PRICE "TO BE ANNOUNCED"

## JAPAN & THE REGION

WORTH THE FLIGHT

**31 Oct–28 Mar** — ★ **Mariko Mori · All That Shines**
MORI ART MUSEUM, 53F ROPPONGI HILLS, TOKYO · ¥2,600–3,000 ADULT, **JUNIOR HIGH AND UNDER FREE** · HER FIRST MAJOR JAPANESE RETROSPECTIVE SINCE 2002 · ***WAVE UFO*** **SLOTS ARE LIMITED — BOOK AHEAD**

**10–24 Jan** — **Grand Sumo · Hatsu Basho**
RYŌGOKU KOKUGIKAN, TOKYO · **GENERAL SALE OPENS SAT 5 DEC** · SEAT PRICES NOT PUBLISHED — AND THE ASSOCIATION'S OWN SITE SAYS THE NOVEMBER BASHO IS "SOLD OUT ALL DATES"

**8 Jan–4 Apr** — **FINAL FANTASY 40th Anniversary Exhibition**
HYOKEIKAN, TOKYO NATIONAL MUSEUM · THE MUSEUM SAYS TICKETS ARE ON SALE · **NO PRICE PUBLISHED**

**4–11 Feb** — ★ **77th Sapporo Snow Festival**
ODORI, TSUDOME AND SUSUKINO, HOKKAIDO · ODORI AND SUSUKINO FREE · **THE ENGLISH SITE STILL SHOWS 2025; ONLY THE JAPANESE ONE CARRIES THESE DATES**

**27–28 Mar** — **AnimeJapan 2027**
**INTEX OSAKA — NOT TOKYO BIG SIGHT.** THE OFFICIAL SITE STATES THE MOVE; LISTINGS SITES STILL SAY TOKYO, WHICH IS 500KM WRONG

**7 MAR** — **Tokyo Marathon 2027**
**LOTTERY RESULTS ISSUED 11 SEPTEMBER; CHARITY CLOSED.** A SPECTATING FIXTURE, NOT A BOOKABLE ONE — AND THE SITE'S VOLUNTEER WINDOW CARRIES TWO CONFLICTING CLOSING DATES

## 24 Nov

THE 11.59PM DEADLINE ON ART SG'S TWO-FOR-ONE, WHICH HALVES A WEEKEND ADULT PAIR FROM S$88 TO S$44[1]

### THE SCEPTIC · WHAT THIS PAGE WILL NOT LIST

Four fixtures a reader would expect are absent, and the reason in each case is the organiser's own page. The **Standard Chartered Singapore Marathon**'s site still describes 2025, with no categories and no fees; **Chingay 2027** publishes no dates, only a 2027 volunteer link; **River Hongbao** still describes the 2026 edition. And the **National Gallery**'s UOB Southeast Asia Gallery is **closed until late 2027**, with no confirmed exhibition published anywhere in this window. Separately, **two October "new openings" in the food round-ups are a year old** — one was reviewed at the same address in May 2025 — and are not on the facing page. Ticketmaster Singapore, the sports hub and SISTIC all refused this desk, so no arena date appears above that a venue or promoter did not confirm.

**SOURCES** 1 Every dated row above was verified at the organiser's, venue's or official ticketing page on 28 October: Esplanade for Soundtracks and Kalaa Utsavam; Wild Rice; Singapore Repertory Theatre; the fair's own tickets page for ART SG; the Kallang venue page for Bruno Mars; the Mori Art Museum; the Japan Sumo Association and its official ticket partner; Tokyo National Museum; the Japanese Sapporo festival site; AnimeJapan; and the Tokyo Marathon. **The Ghibli show is the one exception — organiser-sourced only, because Gardens by the Bay's own calendar renders empty template placeholders and the show's own domain does not resolve. Two barred events stand in this magazine's ledger and appear nowhere above.** Prices are as published; where none is published the row says so rather than estimating.

THE TABLE · FOUR ROOMS, TWO VERDICTS

# Eatbook gives Haji Lane's Yogeek 8 out of 10 for a cleaner tang

*Haji Lane's high-protein frozen yoghurt charges S$4.50 per 100g and a test bowl came to S$11.33; in Joo Chiat, a bagel café got the sharpest line in Singapore food writing this month.*

Two of this month's openings have been eaten by someone who writes it down, which is the only reason they are here. **Yogeek**, at 65 Haji Lane, is self-serve frozen yoghurt sold by weight and pitched at the protein crowd — founded by the people behind a photobooth company. Eatbook scored it **8 out of 10** on 23 September: "Personally, I prefer Yogeek's froyo because it has that distinct yoghurt tang and is less sweet", and it would still recommend it "if you're looking for a cleaner-tasting sweet treat".[1]

The dissent is inside the same review, which is the honest kind. The reviewer concedes that rival Yo-Chi offers more toppings for less money, so what you are buying is tang and restraint rather than value. The mechanics are where people get caught: **S$4.50 per 100g**, weighed at the counter, and the test bowl of plain Original came to **S$11.33**. HungryGoWhere covered it again on 23 October, a month later — steady interest rather than viral. No bookings; watch the scale.[1]

The other verdict is unkind and specific. **Pull by TPG**, a Muslim-owned bagel-sandwich café at #01-03, 60 Joo Chiat Road, trades on punning sandwich names. The Honeycombers' reviewers liked nine of the ten cafés in the same round-up and broke ranks here: **"There's really no fun in the pun if you can't properly execute a basic egg sandwich."** Sandwiches from **S$11.90**, drinks from S$3.90. One review, no counter-review, and Burpple refused this desk — so the fair verdict is over-hyped on concept, under-delivered on the plate, **on a single source**.[2]

Two newer rooms are too new to call, and both earn the trip for reasons other than a score. **Postboy Coffee** sits at #02-01 in the Enabling Village, 20 Lengkok Bahru, inside the I'mable Collective Space: it employs people with disabilities and shows their work on its walls. Food from **S$6.90**, open daily. And **Cafe Yasuragi**, #01-93/94 Millenia Walk, does Japanese comfort food — donburi from **S$15.80** — its aburi mentaiko salmon donburi called "basically a warm hug in food form".[2]

### THE CHATTER · THE BUZZ IS THINNER THAN THE LISTINGS SUGGEST

Four of this month's most-circulated "new openings" did not survive a date check, and the Table is shorter for it. One Mohamed Sultan Road pizzeria appears in an October 2026 round-up; the same publication reviewed it at the same address in **May 2025** and scored it 7.5. A Craig Road restaurant listed as new **opened on 1 October 2025**, with four separate reviews clustered in that autumn. Neither is an opening. Burpple returned 403 on every path, Reddit refused as usual, and Instagram rate-limited this desk — so there is no diner sentiment on this page that was not written by a named reviewer.[3]

### THE SCEPTIC · MUSLIM-OWNED IS NOT CERTIFIED

Two honesty notes the listings skip. **Pull by TPG is described as Muslim-owned, which is not the same as MUIS halal-certified**, and no certification claim appears anywhere this desk could read. And for Yogeek, despite a Kampong Glam address, **neither source states a halal status at all**, so none is asserted. Neither venue publishes a primary page this desk could open: one domain does not resolve, the other rate-limited. Both entries are food-media-sourced, and say so.[4]

**S$11.33**

WHAT A BOWL OF PLAIN ORIGINAL CAME TO AT S$4.50 PER 100G — THE NUMBER THE BY-WEIGHT MODEL HIDES UNTIL THE COUNTER[1]

### STILL ON THE SHELF

**Cafe Nesuto**, at #01-87 The Shoppes at Marina Bay Sands, is running a breakfast platter at **S$32** that The Honeycombers reckons "will definitely keep you full for a good few hours". Opened this autumn; no review score yet.[2]

**SOURCES** 1 Eatbook's review of 23 September 2026, including its own price-per-100g and the bowl total, and HungryGoWhere's listing of 23 October; **the venue's own domain does not resolve and Instagram returned 429, so there is no primary page for it.** 2 The Honeycombers' new-cafés round-up, read 28 October, for Pull by TPG, Postboy Coffee, Cafe Yasuragi and Cafe Nesuto, with addresses and opening prices as published there. 3 Date checks run against the same publications' own earlier reviews; **Burpple returned 403 on all paths, Reddit refused for the fourteenth issue running, Instagram rate-limited, and SethLui's article bodies were unreachable.** 4 Halal status as stated, or not stated, by the sources named — no certification is asserted that this desk could not read.

THE UNDERCURRENT · PAKISTAN'S URDU MODEL

# Pakistan's Buraq promises an Urdu model its own state never wrote in

*Shaza Fatima Khawaja announced a sovereign Urdu large language model in Seoul on 22 October. Urdu is 0.0315 per cent of the crawlable web, and the largest corpus ever assembled in it runs to 1.84 billion tokens.*

On **22 October 2026**, at a World Bank panel in Seoul, Pakistan's IT and telecommunications minister **Shaza Fatima Khawaja** announced **Buraq** — a national large language model for Urdu, to run on "sovereign compute" with Pakistani data held inside Pakistan. Six days later it has no website, no demonstration, no published specification and no release date. What it does have is a justification, and the justification is the most interesting number in Asia this month.[1]

Urdu is **0.0315 per cent** of the crawlable web — of primary-language HTML documents in Common Crawl's October survey. English is 42.5647. Arabic is 0.6675. Hindi, 0.2111. Bengali, 0.1142. Urdu has **more than 230 million speakers** and roughly one three-thousandth of the internet.[2]

That absence is usually told as a market failure: the big labs had no commercial reason to build for Urdu, so somebody must. But read the Pakistani record and a harder explanation appears. **Article 251** of the 1973 constitution gave Urdu fifteen years to replace English in official use. The deadline lapsed in **1988**. In **September 2015** a three-judge Supreme Court bench under Chief Justice **Jawwad S. Khawaja** ordered federal and provincial governments to adopt it, translate all laws within three months and file compliance reports, dismissing English as "the colonial language which cannot be understood by the public at large". Eleven years later the state still drafts, litigates and examines in English.[3]

A language model is trained on what a society has written down. Pakistan is about to discover, in public and at scale, that it did not write itself down in Urdu — because its own institutions were never made to.

The shortfall is not marginal. The largest Urdu pretraining corpus ever assembled is **1.84 billion tokens**, gathered for a model called **Qalb** from news archives, classical and contemporary literature, government documents and social media. Meta trained Llama 3.1 on **more than 15 trillion**. Pakistan's entire national corpus is about **0.012 per cent** of one American base model's diet. The best Urdu instruction dataset in existence contains **51,686** examples — and it is synthetic, generated by machine, because, in its authors' words, "Current Urdu datasets are sparse, manually labeled, and contain only a few thousand instances."[4]

And one of the curated human sources feeding these models is **Urdu Wikipedia**, which has 706,859 content articles and **402 active editors**.[5]

> ***"AI sovereignty is not achieved through language. It is earned through capacity."***

Khawaja's own framing is more careful than the headlines. Buraq, she says, is the top layer on four foundations already built: **NADRA**'s digital identity, covering more than a hundred million people; the State Bank's **Raast** instant payments; **WASL**, the national data-exchange layer; and a national data-governance policy published in June. Her line is the one worth keeping: **"AI is the last layer, not the first."** In the same Seoul week Pakistan became the first country to sign the Digital and AI Compact, which she called "our declaration of independence in the digital era".[1]

**230m**

URDU SPEAKERS, AGAINST 0.0315 PER CENT OF THE CRAWLABLE WEB — ROUGHLY ONE THREE-THOUSANDTH OF THE INTERNET[2]

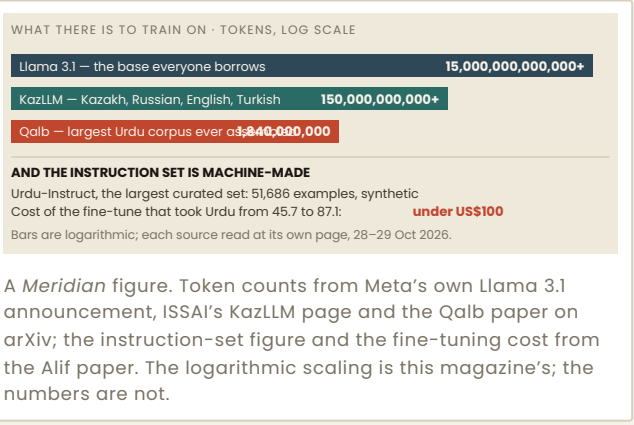
**SOURCES** 1 The Express Tribune's report of the Seoul announcement, 22 October 2026, and the ministry's own published keynote text of 19 October; **Buraq has no page of its own anywhere, which is reported as an absence.** 2 Common Crawl's own language statistics for crawl CC-MAIN-2026-43, language identification by CLD2, read 29 October; the speaker figure from Pakistan's state news agency. 3 Dawn's report of the Supreme Court judgment of 8 September 2015, quoting the bench. 4 The Qalb paper on arXiv for the corpus size; Meta's own Llama 3.1 announcement for the comparison; the Alif paper for the instruction set and the quoted sentence. 5 Urdu Wikipedia's own Special:Statistics page, read 28–29 October.

Here is the second thing the record shows, and it is more awkward than the first. Every "indigenous" Urdu model built so far is a foreign one wearing an Urdu name.

**Alif-1.0-8B-Instruct**, trained in February 2025, is a continued pretrain of Meta's Llama 3.1 8B. It lifted Urdu performance from a weighted average of **45.7 to 87.1**. It was done on one A100 at **US$1.64 an hour for 39 hours — a total under US$100**. **Qalb**, submitted in January 2026 by three Pakistani graduate students, added the 1.84-billion-token corpus on the same Llama base and reached **90.34**. Its lead author, Muhammad Taimoor Hassan, is doing a master's at Auburn; two teammates are studying in Germany.[1]

The state's own Urdu assistant, launched in Islamabad in October 2025, was built with **Meta**. And the telecoms route is stranger still. In November 2024 **Jazz** signed with NUST and the national IT board to build "Pakistan's first indigenous LLM". In February 2026, at a business forum in Islamabad attended by President Tokayev, **QazCode** signed with Jazz to build an Urdu model **on the architecture of KazLLM**, Kazakhstan's open-source national model, with Kazakh-supplied datasets and evaluation scenarios. The Kazakh press called it technological diplomacy.[2]

It is also an internal transfer. **Jazz in Pakistan and Beeline Kazakhstan, QazCode's parent, are both Veon companies.** The gift crosses a border and not a balance sheet.[2]




A *Meridian* figure. Token counts from Meta's own Llama 3.1 announcement, ISSAI's KazLLM page and the Qalb paper on arXiv; the instruction-set figure and the fine-tuning cost from the Alif paper. The logarithmic scaling is this magazine's; the numbers are not.

So what is left of sovereignty? Read the **Islamabad AI Declaration**, adopted in February and published by the ministry itself, and the answer is: jurisdiction. Nine principles, including "SOVEREIGN DATA, TRUSTED STEWARDSHIP" and, as Principle 8, "PRIVATE-SECTOR-LED, SOVEREIGN COMPUTE". The data stays in the country; the compute is subcontracted. **And the Declaration does not contain the word Urdu.** Not once. The state's own flagship AI framework names its constraint as hardware and jurisdiction, and never mentions text at all.[3]

> ***"The picture is one of a declaration that promises sovereign AI and never says the language."***

The money is committed. Prime minister **Shehbaz Sharif** opened Indus AI Week in February with **US$1 billion to 2030**, a thousand funded AI doctorates, AI in federal school curricula, and training for a million non-IT professionals. The July 2025 national policy allocated **2,000 megawatts** of electricity to AI data centres and high-tech infrastructure. Six months after that policy, by one report, the National AI Council had still not been formed and the provinces had not replied.[4]

The pattern holds at the level of the state as well. Pakistan's July 2025 national AI policy promised a million AI experts by 2030, three thousand scholarships a year, a thousand homegrown products and an AI Council. By **March 2026**, six months on, one report found the Council had not been formed, the provinces had not answered requests for input, and awareness activity was the only pillar visibly moving. Dawn's own coverage of the February pledge noted that implementation of the 2025 policy "has stalled". The money is newer than the machinery it is meant to fund.[4]

**2,000MW**

ELECTRICITY ALLOCATED TO AI DATA CENTRES AND HIGH-TECH INFRASTRUCTURE BY THE JULY 2025 NATIONAL POLICY, WHOSE AI COUNCIL HAD STILL NOT BEEN FORMED SIX MONTHS LATER[4]

**SOURCES** 1 The Alif paper, arXiv 2510.09051, for the base model, the scores and the US$100 training cost; the Qalb paper, arXiv 2601.08141, for the corpus and the 90.34; Pakistan's state news agency and ProPakistani for the authors. 2 Developing Telecoms on the November 2024 Jazz agreement, which also records QazCode as the software arm of Beeline Kazakhstan; the Kazakh outlet DKNews on the February 2026 memorandum; Aaj English on the Meta-built state assistant. **Whether the state's "ALIF" and the independent Alif-1.0 are the same artefact could not be established and is not asserted.** 3 The Islamabad AI Declaration, read in full at the ministry's own site; **the date is given as 9 February by the ministry and 10 February by one business daily, and the absence of the word Urdu was checked against the ministry's own text.** 4 The Press Information Department's own release on the US$1bn pledge, with Dawn's coverage; the national policy's megawatt allocation via The Friday Times; **the implementation-failure report is single-sourced.**

Three precedents make the shape of this clearer than any forecast.

The first is **Noori Nastaliq**, 1981. Mirza Ahmad Jamil designed it with Monotype — roughly **18,000 hand-drawn ligatures** — and Pakistan declared it an "Invention of National Importance" the following year. It was also proprietary, tied to one imagesetter, and hard to carry into the technologies that followed. That is the pattern, forty-five years old: Urdu enters each new medium as a bespoke artefact co-produced with a foreign vendor, is declared a triumph, and fails to compound into a reusable public resource. Alif on Llama, Jazz on KazLLM, Buraq on sovereign compute — same shape, new decade. Nastaliq's overlapping cursive forms are also what makes mass optical character recognition of the printed backlist so hard, which is part of why the corpus is thin.[1]

The second is Japan's **Fifth Generation Computer Systems** project, 1982 to 1994. MITI spent a little under **¥57 billion** — about US$320 million — through ICOT to build bespoke parallel machines for logic programming. It produced five Parallel Inference Machines and no commercial success: commodity workstations overtook the special-purpose hardware, and afterwards MITI stopped funding large-scale computer research. It is the exact rhyme for a from-scratch decision, and Pakistan has already run the experiment in-house. **US$100 of fine-tuning on somebody else's model scored 87.1.**[2]

WHO IS WRITING IT DOWN · WIKIPEDIA, READ 28–29 OCT 2026

| LANGUAGE | ARTICLES | ACTIVE EDITORS | ARTICLES EACH |
|---|---|---|---|
| English | 7,256,448 | 270,134 | 26.9 |
| Hindi | 172,172 | 970 | 177.5 |
| **Urdu** | **706,859** | **402** | **1,758.4** |

Bar is articles per active editor. Urdu Wikipedia is a named curated source for these models.

A *Meridian* figure. Counts read at each wiki's own Special:Statistics page; the ratio is arithmetic.

The third precedent is the 2015 Supreme Court order itself, and it turns this from bad luck into a verdict. The corpus gap is not an accident of commerce but an adjudicated failure of language policy, measurable in tokens. **The state cannot make its own bureaucracy write Urdu; it has nonetheless promised to make a machine do so.** The missing training data is the unenforced judgment.[3]

The sceptics in Pakistan have already said most of this, and said it in Pakistan. **Sarah Siddiq Aneel**, writing in February and republished by the Sustainable Development Policy Institute, credits the Declaration's restraint and then takes it apart: without multi-year investment and policy stability, sovereignty "risks becoming rhetorical"; human-in-the-loop governance without trained auditors and liability law is "procedural rather than practical"; there are no priority sectors, no metrics and no timeline, so **"The declaration is not operational"**; and data localisation is "more of a greenwash". Her closing line is the one to keep: **"In the end, AI sovereignty is not achieved through language. It is earned through capacity."**[4]

**Asad Baig** of Media Matters for Democracy, in Dawn in June, adds the physical objection: the policy "treats the technology too often as an application, a chatbot, a pilot project"; the 2,000-megawatt announcement conflates speculative crypto mining with sovereign AI compute; the real constraint is access to data-centre accelerators that may need American export licences; and Pakistan is "training AI on local data before it has enacted a comprehensive" data-protection law. There is no AI statute; the Regulation of Artificial Intelligence Act remains before parliament, and the Personal Data Protection Bill is not law.[4]

What a reader outside Pakistan should take from this is not a prediction about one model. It is a test anyone can now run on any state that announces a sovereign AI. A large language model is a retrospective audit of a country's written record, and the audit cannot be bought. Compute can be rented, weights can be borrowed, residency can be legislated. **Text is the one input that has to have been written, by someone, at the time.** The cheap and unglamorous version of sovereignty is a corpus: digitise the law reports, the assembly record, the textbooks, the seventy-eight-year Urdu press archive, the Nastaliq backlist that OCR still mangles. It is a public good only a state can build. No line of the Islamabad Declaration commits to it — and the Declaration, remember, never says the word.[5]

**SOURCES** 1 The Reviving Type Database's entry on Noori Nastaliq for the 1981 design, the ligature count and the 1982 designation. 2 The documented record of Japan's Fifth Generation Computer Systems project, 1982–1994, for the budget, the machines produced and MITI's withdrawal; the US$100 comparison from the Alif paper. 3 Dawn's report of the 8 September 2015 judgment; Article 251's lapsed 1988 deadline. 4 Sarah Siddiq Aneel via the Sustainable Development Policy Institute, 23 February 2026; Asad Baig in Dawn, 12 June 2026; the regulatory position from The Friday Times. 5 The Islamabad AI Declaration at the ministry's own site. **Buraq itself remains unbuilt as far as any public record shows: no builder, no architecture, no timeline, no budget line, and no page of its own. Seven Pakistani and international outlets refused this desk, including two national dailies, which is why the local voice on these pages is columnists and one comment thread rather than a forum.**

THE LAST WORD

# The measurement nobody took

A clearance is a small thing. On Wednesday morning a control centre in Madrid told six halted trains they could go again, under rules that cap a train at forty kilometres an hour. One of them reached the back of another at about two hundred. The rule existed. The number existed. What did not travel, somewhere between the desk and the cab, was the one figure that mattered.

The same shape turned up all week without being hunted. A company states its revenue to the dollar and its largest obligation as “more than $ ”, five times (p7). A central bank votes on inflation the day before the inflation figure is published, and calls the gap “the accumulation of more information” (p14). A flagship headphone goes on sale in three continents and, five days later, not one laboratory anywhere has put a microphone in front of it (p10). Twenty-two schools ban phones and the study finds nothing clears its own threshold, which is a result, not an absence (p12). A craft’s national society has run since 1952 and will not say how many members it has (p15).

Two pages complicate it, and they are the reason this is not a complaint. On p18 the measurement was finally taken — nine days of wrist accelerometer, scored by a named algorithm, against a nurse timing a walk of two and a half metres — and the expensive instrument added nothing. And on p21 a state proposes to build a language model in a language it has spent seventy-eight years declining to govern in. It can rent the compute and borrow the weights. The text had to have been written, by someone, at the time.

TWELVE DESKS · ONE WORLD

MERIDIAN · No. 147 · 29 October 2026

SOURCES A note on method. This edition’s load-bearing figures were read where they are published: a registration statement downloaded whole from the Securities and Exchange Commission’s archive and searched on this desk; the Federal Open Market Committee’s statement and implementation note, extracted from the Federal Reserve’s own PDF; the United States Treasury’s daily yield curve; Australia’s monthly consumer price index at the statistical agency; four journal papers at their journals; a Singapore ministry’s own press release and two parliamentary replies; Common Crawl’s own language statistics and three Wikipedias’ own statistics pages; two arXiv papers; a Linak data sheet from Linak’s own CDN; merge requests and issues on a public code repository; makers’ own storefronts in six currencies; and promoter, venue or museum pages for every dated event on p19. Figures that are this magazine’s own arithmetic — the $637bn compute sum on p7, the logarithmic scaling on p22, the articles-per-editor ratio on p23 — all say so where they appear. Where a host refused us — Reddit for the fourteenth issue running, and so there is no Reddit sentiment anywhere in this book; Reuters, the Associated Press, the BBC and the Guardian; Israel’s elections committee, whose portal serves nothing but a browser; Brazil’s electoral court; Adif’s press room; Audio-Technica in every region, for a second issue; Billboard, Metacritic’s music pages and Pitchfork, which is why p11 carries no album aggregate; Burpple, SethLui and Instagram; Singapore’s two main ticketing sites; CITES; Vitra, Herman Miller and Steelcase; and two Pakistani national dailies — the page says so rather than quietly substituting. A correction to No. 146 runs on p7: the prospectus does not blank its third-quarter revenue, it stops before it. Every photograph in this issue was opened and looked at before it was captioned.